FUTURES MATTER EDUCATION

Futures Matter - Northwood, 122 Emily Street, Highgate, Birmingham, B12 0XJ

Safeguarding and Child Protection Policy

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Reviewed by: Benjamin Neasom, Head Teacher
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Mark O'Donnell, Chair of School Governance Board

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Important contacts. Anyone with a safeguarding concern about a pupil should speak to the Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL) at once, on 0121 835 1360. In an emergency, or if a child is in immediate danger, call the police on 999. Cleaners, caretakers, contractors and other adults who do not use CPOMS or email can report a concern in person, by phone or on an offline concern card (see section 7.11 and Appendix 7). Out of school hours, use the numbers in Appendix 8.

Role or organisation	Name and contact details
Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)	Benjamin Neasom, Head Teacher. School telephone 0121 835 1360. Mobile 07521 013 526
Deputy DSL	Carrie-Ann McGurk, Proprietor. School telephone 0121 835 1360
Deputy DSL	Simone Welch. School telephone 0121 835 1360
Safeguarding email (monitored by the DSL and both deputies)	safeguarding@futuresmattereducation.co.uk
Chair of the School Governance Board	Mark O'Donnell c.o.g@futuresmattereducation.co.uk
Children's Advice and Support Service (CASS), Birmingham Children's Trust	0121 303 1888. Monday to Thursday 08:45 to 17:15, Friday 08:45 to 16:15. Emergency out of hours: 0121 675 4806
Local Authority Designated Officer (LADO), Birmingham Children's Trust	0121 675 1669. Email ladoteam@birminghamchildrenstrust.co.uk (send referrals to the team email, not to a named officer)
Adult Social Care Access Point (ACAP)	0121 303 1234. Monday to Friday 09:00 to 17:00. Emergency out of hours: 0121 675 4806
Channel helpline (DfE, concerns about extremism)	020 7340 7264 (not for emergencies). Email counter.extremism@education.gov.uk
NSPCC helpline for professionals	0808 800 5000
Police	999 in an emergency, 101 otherwise. Anti-terrorist hotline 0800 789 321

This policy sets out the safeguarding and child protection policy and procedures for Futures Matter - Northwood, run by Futures Matter Education. It follows the structure of the model child protection policy and the Department for Education's statutory guidance Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026 (KCSIE). Further information and procedures are available from the Birmingham Safeguarding Children Partnership (BSCP).

1.0 AIMS

Futures Matter - Northwood is a small independent special school for pupils aged 11 to 16 with social, emotional and mental health (SEMH) needs and autism. All of our pupils have an education, health and care (EHC) plan. We aim to make sure that:

- appropriate action is taken in a timely manner to safeguard and promote children's welfare
- all staff are aware of their statutory responsibilities with respect to safeguarding
- staff are properly trained in recognising and reporting safeguarding issues
- safeguarding is a golden thread that runs through everything we do, so that pupils feel safe and can be safe, at school and on the way to and from school

Our approach is child-centred. We consider the wishes, feelings and best interests of each child, we give children a voice, we listen to them and take them seriously, and we work with others to meet their needs. This policy applies to everyone in our school, including extended school and off-site activities, and to any provision we commission on our behalf, including alternative provision.

2.0 LEGISLATION AND STATUTORY GUIDANCE

This policy is based on the Department for Education's (DfE's) statutory guidance Keeping Children Safe in Education (2026) and Working Together to Safeguard Children (2026). We comply with this guidance and with the arrangements agreed and published by our 3 local safeguarding partners (Birmingham City Council, the Integrated Care Board and West Midlands Police), through the Birmingham Safeguarding Children Partnership. It is also based on:

- Part 3 of the schedule to The Education (Independent School Standards) Regulations 2014, which places a duty on independent schools to safeguard and promote the welfare of pupils at the school
- the Children Act 1989 (and 2004 amendment), which provides a framework for the care and protection of children, including the duty in section 16LA of the 2004 Act to share information to safeguard children
- the statutory guidance on information sharing to safeguard children and young people
- section 5B(11) of the Female Genital Mutilation Act 2003, as inserted by section 74 of the Serious Crime Act 2015, which places a statutory duty on teachers to report to the police where they discover that female genital mutilation (FGM) appears to have been carried out on a girl under 18, and the statutory guidance on FGM
- the Rehabilitation of Offenders Act 1974, which outlines when people with criminal convictions can work with children
- Schedule 4 of the Safeguarding Vulnerable Groups Act 2006 (as amended by the Protection of Freedoms Act 2012 and the Crime and Policing Act 2026), which defines 'regulated activity' in relation to children
- the statutory guidance on the Prevent duty, which explains our duties under the Counter-Terrorism and Security Act 2015 to protect people from the risk of radicalisation and extremism

- the Human Rights Act 1998, which explains that being subjected to harassment, violence or abuse, including of a sexual nature, may breach the rights that apply to individuals under the European Convention on Human Rights
- the Equality Act 2010, which makes it unlawful to discriminate against people regarding protected characteristics (age, disability, gender reassignment, marriage and civil partnership, race, religion or belief, sex and sexual orientation), including the duty to make reasonable adjustments for disabled pupils, and the Public Sector Equality Duty (PSED) to have due regard to eliminating unlawful discrimination, harassment and victimisation
- the Operation Encompass statutory guidance, which explains that the police must notify the relevant education setting of any incident involving domestic abuse
- the UK GDPR, the Data Protection Act 2018 and the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025, which govern how we handle safeguarding information (and which do not prevent us sharing information to keep children safe)

As our school has no pupils under 8 and no Early Years Foundation Stage (EYFS) provision, the 2018 Childcare Disqualification Regulations and the EYFS safeguarding requirements do not apply to us. We follow local multi-agency procedures put in place by the 3 safeguarding partners and update this policy when they change.

3.0 DEFINITIONS

Safeguarding and promoting the welfare of children means:

- providing help and support to meet the needs of children as soon as problems emerge
- protecting children from maltreatment, whether that is within or outside the home, including online
- preventing impairment of children's mental and physical health or development
- ensuring that children grow up in circumstances consistent with the provision of safe and effective care
- taking action to enable all children to have the best outcomes

Child protection is part of this definition and refers to activities undertaken to protect specific children who are suspected to be suffering, or likely to suffer, significant harm, whether inside or outside the home, including online.

Abuse is a form of maltreatment of a child, and may involve inflicting harm or failing to act to prevent harm. Appendix 1 explains the different types of abuse. **Neglect** is a form of abuse: the persistent failure to meet a child's basic physical and/or psychological needs, likely to result in the serious impairment of the child's health or development.

Making or sharing of nudes or semi-nudes is where children share nude or semi-nude images, such as photographs, videos or live streams. It also includes images that are digitally altered or wholly AI-generated (sometimes called 'deepfakes' or 'deep nudes') that appear to be a photograph or video. Sharing nudes or semi-nudes requires a safeguarding response whether it is consensual or non-consensual.

Children includes everyone under the age of 18.

The **3 safeguarding partners** are the local authority, the integrated care board for the area and the chief officer of police for the area. They make arrangements to work together to safeguard and promote the welfare of local children.

Victim is a widely understood term, but not everyone who has been subjected to abuse considers themselves a victim or wants to be described that way. When managing an incident, we will use any term that the child involved feels most comfortable with. **Alleged perpetrator(s)** and **perpetrator(s)** are widely used terms. We will think carefully about the terminology we use, especially in front of children, as abusive behaviour can be harmful to the perpetrator too. We decide which terms to use case by case.

Safeguarding includes child protection but is much broader. All staff are aware of our collective responsibility to act to protect children from all sources and types of harm, as set out in KCSIE and in this policy, including physical, sexual and emotional abuse and neglect, bullying and prejudice-based bullying, gender-based violence and violence against women and girls, misogyny and misandry, sexual violence and sexual harassment, radicalisation, child sexual and criminal exploitation, modern slavery and trafficking, gang involvement and serious violence, making or sharing nudes and semi-nudes, substance misuse, domestic abuse, so-called 'honour-based' abuse, and perplexing presentations and fabricated or induced illness.

4.0 EQUALITY STATEMENT

Some children have an increased risk of abuse, both online and offline, and additional barriers can exist for some children with respect to recognising or disclosing it. We are committed to anti-discriminatory practice and recognise children's diverse circumstances. We make sure that all children have the same protection, regardless of any barriers they may face.

Cultural competence. We respect the cultural, ethnic, faith and language backgrounds of our pupils and families. We use interpreters and translated information where they are needed, and we avoid jargon. We base decisions on evidence about a child's safety and not on assumptions about a culture or community, and we never let a cultural practice, belief or tradition outweigh a child's safety, for example in cases of FGM, forced marriage or so-called 'honour'-based abuse. Our Equality, Diversity and Inclusion Policy sets out how we record and respond to prejudice-related incidents, which staff report to the DSL.

All of our pupils have special educational needs and disabilities (SEND), so every pupil is treated as potentially more vulnerable. We give special consideration to children who:

- have SEND or health conditions (see sections 10 and 11)
- are young carers (section 12)
- may experience discrimination due to their race, ethnicity, religion, gender identification or sexuality
- have English as an additional language (EAL)
- are known to be living in difficult situations, for example temporary accommodation, or where there are issues such as substance abuse or domestic violence
- are at risk of FGM, sexual exploitation, forced marriage or radicalisation
- are asylum seekers
- are at risk due to their own or a family member's mental health needs

- are looked after or previously looked after (section 14)
- are missing or absent from education for prolonged periods and/or frequently
- have a parent or carer who has expressed an intention to remove them from school to be home educated

5.0 ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

Safeguarding and child protection is everyone's responsibility. This policy applies to all staff, volunteers, members of the School Governance Board and the Proprietor, and is consistent with the procedures of the 3 safeguarding partners. It also applies to extended school and off-site activities.

We play a crucial role in preventative education. This is part of a whole-school approach to preparing pupils for life in modern Britain, and a culture of zero tolerance of sexism, racism, misogyny and misandry, homophobia, biphobia, transphobia, sexual violence and harassment, derogatory behaviour and other forms of physical violence and conflict. It is underpinned by our Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy, our pastoral support system and our planned programme of relationships, sex and health education (RSHE), which is inclusive and delivered regularly. It covers healthy and respectful relationships, boundaries and consent, stereotyping, prejudice and equality, body confidence and self-esteem, how to recognise an abusive relationship (including coercive and controlling behaviour), the law on sexual consent, sexual exploitation, abuse, grooming, coercion, harassment, rape, domestic abuse and so-called honour-based violence (including forced marriage and FGM), how to get support, and what sexual harassment and sexual violence are and why they are always unacceptable. See our RSHE Policy for how this is taught to pupils with SEMH needs and autism.

5.1 All staff

All staff will:

- read and understand at least part 1 of KCSIE 2026 (and, for staff who do not work directly with children, the guidance for them) and review it at least annually
- sign a declaration at the beginning of each academic year to say that they have read and reviewed the guidance
- reinforce the importance of online safety when communicating with parents and carers, including making them aware of what we ask children to do online (for example, sites they need to visit or who they will interact with)
- provide a safe space for pupils who are LGBTQ+ to speak out and share their concerns

All staff will be aware of:

- our systems that support safeguarding, including this policy, the Staff Code of Conduct, the roles and identities of the DSL and both deputy DSLs, the Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy, our Online Safety Policy (including the expectations, applicable roles and responsibilities in relation to filtering and monitoring) and the safeguarding response to children who are absent from, or go missing from, education

- our unauthorised absence procedures and children missing education procedures (see our Attendance Policy and our Children Missing Education and Missing Pupils Policy)
- the early help assessment process and their role in it, including identifying emerging problems, liaising with the DSL, and sharing information with other professionals to support early identification and assessment
- the process for making referrals to local authority children's social care and for the statutory assessments that may follow, including the role they might be expected to play
- the process for community-based Family Help assessments
- what to do if they identify a safeguarding issue or a child tells them they are being abused or neglected, including specific issues such as FGM, and how to maintain an appropriate level of confidentiality while liaising with relevant professionals
- the signs of different types of abuse, neglect, exploitation and modern slavery, including domestic and sexual abuse (including controlling and coercive behaviour, and parental conflict that is frequent, intense and unresolved), and specific safeguarding issues such as child-on-child abuse, grooming, child sexual exploitation (CSE), child criminal exploitation (CCE), indicators of being at risk from or involved with serious violent crime, FGM, radicalisation and serious violence (including that linked to county lines)
- the safeguarding issues that often overlap and can put children at risk of harm: drug taking and alcohol misuse; unexplained and persistent absences from education; serious violence, criminal exploitation and radicalisation; consensual and non-consensual making or sharing of nudes and semi-nudes; and new and emerging threats, including online harm, grooming, sexual and criminal exploitation, radicalisation, and the role of technology and social media in presenting harm
- the importance of reassuring victims that they are being taken seriously and that they will be supported and kept safe
- the fact that children can be at risk of harm inside and outside their home, at school and online
- the fact that mental health can, in some cases, develop into safeguarding concerns, such as self-harm, suicidal ideation or risk of suicide, and can also be an indicator that a child has suffered or is at risk of suffering abuse, neglect or exploitation
- the fact that children who are (or are perceived to be) lesbian, gay or bisexual can be vulnerable to discriminatory bullying, and the potential vulnerabilities of children who are questioning their gender
- the fact that children may experience prejudice-based harm, including racism, faith-based prejudice and other forms of discrimination, which can affect a child's welfare, wellbeing, mental health and ability to seek help
- the fact that a child and their family may be experiencing multiple needs at the same time
- what to look for to identify children who need help or protection

Appendix 4 explains in more detail how staff are supported to do this.

5.2 The designated safeguarding lead (DSL) and deputies

The DSL is a member of the senior leadership team. The DSL at our school is Benjamin Neasom, Head Teacher. The DSL takes lead responsibility for child protection and wider safeguarding in the school. This includes online safety, and understanding our filtering and monitoring processes on school devices and the school network to keep pupils safe online. The ultimate lead responsibility for safeguarding stays with the DSL and is not delegated, although activities can be delegated to the trained deputies.

During term time, the DSL is available during school hours for staff to discuss any safeguarding concerns, on 0121 835 1360. **Out of hours DSL mobile number: 07521 013526.**

The deputy DSLs are Carrie-Ann McGurk and Simone Welch, who is trained as a deputy DSL. When the DSL is absent, the deputy DSLs act as cover. If the DSL and one deputy are unavailable, the other deputy acts. If none of the three is available, our cover arrangements are that concerns can be sent to the confidential safeguarding mailbox: **safeguarding@futuresmattereducationc.co.uk** which all three can access, and staff will take advice from CASS (0121 303 1888) without delay; the Chair of the School Governance Board is informed that cover was not available.

The DSL will be given the time, funding, training, resources and support to:

- provide advice and support to other staff on child welfare and child protection matters
- take part in strategy discussions and inter-agency meetings, and/or support other staff to do so
- contribute to the assessment of children
- refer suspected cases, as appropriate, to the relevant body (local authority children's social care, the Channel programme, the Disclosure and Barring Service (DBS), the police), and support staff who make such referrals directly
- have a good understanding of harmful sexual behaviour
- have a good understanding of the filtering and monitoring systems and processes in place at our school
- make sure staff have appropriate Prevent training and induction (the DSL is our Prevent single point of contact)
- keep the Head Teacher informed of any issues (the DSL is the Head Teacher, so the Chair of the School Governance Board is kept informed through the annual report and any serious matter)
- liaise with local authority case managers and designated officers for child protection concerns as appropriate
- discuss the local response to sexual violence and sexual harassment with the police and local authority children's social care to prepare our policies
- be confident about what local specialist support is available to children involved (victims and alleged perpetrators) in sexual violence and sexual harassment, and how to access it
- be aware that children must have an 'appropriate adult' to support them in a police investigation or search
- make sure child protection files are kept up to date on CPOMS, and, where children leave, that their file is transferred to the new school (section 18)

The DSL is also our Operation Encompass key adult. The full responsibilities of the DSL and the deputy DSLs are set out in their job descriptions.

5.3 The School Governance Board and Proprietor

The School Governance Board and the Proprietor have strategic responsibility for our safeguarding arrangements. The Board will:

- make sure safeguarding and child protection are at the forefront of, and underpin, all relevant aspects of process and policy development
- make sure all staff who work directly with children read at least part 1 of KCSIE, and those who do not read the guidance for them
- evaluate and approve this policy at each review, make sure it complies with the law, and hold the Head Teacher to account for its implementation
- be aware of its obligations under the Human Rights Act 1998, the Equality Act 2010 (including the Public Sector Equality Duty) and our local multi-agency safeguarding arrangements
- appoint a senior board-level lead to monitor the effectiveness of this policy with the full Board. This is always a different person from the DSL. At our school this is the Chair, Mark O'Donnell
- make sure all staff undergo safeguarding and child protection training, including online safety, that it is regularly updated and in line with advice from the safeguarding partners
- make sure we have a policy on the use of restrictive interventions, including the use of reasonable force, which reflects that a 'no contact' policy can leave staff unable to fully support and protect pupils (see our Restrictive Interventions Policy)
- make sure we have appropriate cyber security systems in place (see our Cyber Security Policy and Response Plan)
- make sure we have appropriate filtering and monitoring systems in place and review their effectiveness at least once every academic year. This includes making sure leaders and staff understand their expectations, roles and responsibilities around filtering and monitoring as part of safeguarding training; making sure the review is carried out by the senior leader responsible for filtering and monitoring, with the support of the DSL and IT support, including checks that filtering is working on all internet-connected devices in all relevant locations, with a record of those checks kept; and reviewing the DfE's filtering and monitoring standards and discussing with IT staff and service providers what is needed to meet them
- make sure the DSL has the appropriate status and authority to carry out their job, including additional time, funding, training, resources and support, and that online safety is a running and interrelated theme within our whole-school approach to safeguarding and related policies
- make sure we have procedures to manage any safeguarding concerns (no matter how small) or allegations that do not meet the harm threshold (low-level concerns) about staff, including supply staff, trainee teachers, volunteers and contractors (Appendix 3)
- make sure this policy reflects that children with SEND, or certain medical or physical health conditions, can face additional barriers to any abuse or neglect being recognised

- where another body provides services or activities on our premises, whether or not the children attending are on our roll: seek assurance that it has appropriate safeguarding and child protection policies and procedures, and inspect them if needed; make sure there are arrangements for it to liaise with us about safeguarding; and make safeguarding requirements a condition of using our premises, with any agreement ending if the body fails to comply

The Chair of the School Governance Board acts as the 'case manager' if an allegation of abuse is made against the Head Teacher (Appendix 3). All members of the Board and the Proprietor will read KCSIE in its entirety, and receive safeguarding training at induction, updated regularly (section 19.3). The governance role is strategic, not operational: the Board does not get involved in concerns about individual pupils. Our Board also reviews safeguarding data, an annual safeguarding report from the DSL, and our Section 175 style self-assessment audit.

5.4 The Head Teacher

The Head Teacher is responsible for the implementation of this policy, including:

- making sure staff (including temporary staff) and volunteers are informed of our systems that support safeguarding, including this policy, as part of their induction, and understand and follow the procedures in it, particularly those concerning referrals of cases of suspected abuse and neglect
- communicating this policy to parents and carers when their child joins the school, and on our website
- making sure the DSL has appropriate time, funding, training and resources, and that there is always adequate cover if the DSL is absent
- acting as the 'case manager' in the event of an allegation of abuse made against another member of staff or volunteer, where appropriate (Appendix 3)
- making decisions about all low-level concerns, although the Head Teacher may collaborate with the DSL, where the concern allows

Because the Head Teacher is also the DSL, a concern about the Head Teacher goes straight to the Chair of the School Governance Board (section 7.7).

5.5 Virtual school heads

Virtual school heads (VSHs) have a non-statutory responsibility for the strategic oversight of the educational attendance, attainment and progress of pupils with a social worker, and to promote the educational achievement of children in kinship care (children who live with a relative or close family friend). VSHs also identify and engage with key professionals such as DSLs, SENCOs, social workers and mental health leads. We work with the VSH of each placing local authority.

6.0 CONFIDENTIALITY AND INFORMATION SHARING

Safeguarding and child protection information is dealt with in a confidential manner and shared only with those who need to know it. Our Data Protection Policy and Privacy Notices explain how we handle personal data. Our approach to sharing information for safeguarding is as follows:

- **The statutory duty.** Under section 16LA of the Children Act 2004, we have a statutory duty to share information with other relevant organisations if we consider that we hold information that is relevant to safeguarding or promoting a child's welfare, or if we receive a request for relevant information from another organisation or practitioner
- we will share information with other organisations and practitioners if it is considered that sharing may help the recipient's relevant functions, including assessing need, making a decision, providing support or taking action to safeguard and promote the welfare of a child
- timely information sharing is essential to effective safeguarding. Fears about sharing information must not stand in the way of promoting the welfare and protecting the safety of a child, and must not prevent us from fulfilling our legal duty
- we have arrangements that set out the process and principles for sharing information within the school and with local authority children's social care, the safeguarding partners and other organisations, agencies and practitioners as required
- **Thresholds.** The duty to share is not limited to situations where a child is in immediate danger or meets child protection thresholds. Relevant information must also be shared where it is relevant to safeguarding and promoting a child's welfare, including where concerns relate to early help, prevention and unmet need
- **Rare exceptions.** In extremely limited circumstances we will not share information where we consider that doing so would be more detrimental to the child than not sharing. Examples are the child being placed at immediate risk of harm by the information being shared; interfering with a police investigation so that the consequence is likely to be of greater detriment to a child, including placing another child at increased risk; and contravening the Family Procedure Rules or an order of the Family Court or the Family Division of the High Court. Any decision not to share will be rare, carefully considered, recorded, and with the welfare of the child central to the judgement
- the Data Protection Act 2018, the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025 and the UK GDPR do not prevent or limit the sharing of information to keep children safe. Data protection must not be treated as a reason to withhold information where the statutory duty applies
- **Consent and confidentiality.** When we share information under the section 16LA duty, the common law duty of confidentiality does not apply. The statutory guidance warns against asking for consent to share information that the duty requires us to share, because that gives children and families a 'false choice'. We will identify the right lawful basis from the start and explain what will happen, rather than asking for permission, where consent is not required or would be inappropriate for safeguarding purposes, unless doing so would put the child at greater risk
- staff must never promise a child that they will not tell anyone about a report of abuse. It may not be in the child's best interests, and it conflicts with our statutory duty
- if staff are in any doubt about sharing information, they should speak to the DSL or a deputy
- we will only use information received under the information-sharing duty for the specified purposes

If a victim asks us not to tell anyone about sexual violence or sexual harassment. There is no definitive answer, but staff must recognise that the statutory duty to share relevant information overrides a victim's request for complete confidentiality. The DSL will balance the victim's wishes against their legal duty to protect the victim and other pupils and staff. A decision to withhold information will only happen in the extremely limited circumstances described above. The DSL will consider that parents and carers should normally be informed (unless this would put the victim at greater risk), and that the basic safeguarding principle stays the same: if a child is at risk of harm, is in immediate danger or has been harmed, a referral must be made to local authority children's social care. Rape, assault by penetration and sexual assault are crimes, and a report of one of them will be referred to the police. The age of criminal responsibility is 10, but if the alleged perpetrator is under 10 the starting principle of referring to the police remains.

Anonymity. Where an allegation of sexual violence or sexual harassment is progressing through the criminal justice system, all staff will be aware of anonymity, witness support and the criminal process in general. They will do all they reasonably can to protect the anonymity of any children involved in any report, for example by carefully considering which staff should know about the report and what support children need, and they will consider the potential impact of social media in spreading rumours and exposing victims' identities.

Confidentiality is also covered in section 18 (record-keeping) and in Appendix 3 (allegations against staff).

7.0 RECOGNISING ABUSE AND TAKING ACTION

All staff are expected to be able to identify and recognise all forms of abuse, neglect, exploitation and modern slavery, and to be alert to the potential need for early help for a child who:

- has a disability or certain health conditions and has specific additional needs
- has special educational needs (whether or not they have an EHC plan). All of our pupils have SEND
- has a mental health need
- is a young carer
- is pregnant and/or is a parent themselves
- has exhibited early signs of abusive, violent and/or harmful behaviours
- is bereaved
- is showing early signs of being drawn into anti-social or criminal behaviour, including gang involvement and association with organised crime groups or county lines
- is frequently missing, or goes missing, from education, care or home
- has been repeatedly removed from the classroom, experienced multiple suspensions, is on a part-time timetable, or is at risk of permanent exclusion
- is at risk of exploitation, modern slavery, trafficking, or sexual and/or criminal exploitation
- is at risk of being radicalised into terrorism
- has a parent or carer in custody, or is affected by parental offending
- is viewing problematic or inappropriate online content (for example, linked to violence), or developing inappropriate relationships online

- is in a family circumstance presenting challenges for the child, such as drug and alcohol misuse, adult mental health issues and domestic abuse
- is misusing drugs or alcohol
- has returned home to their family from care
- is at risk of so-called 'honour'-based abuse such as FGM or forced marriage
- is a privately fostered child

Staff, volunteers and members of the School Governance Board must follow the procedures below in the event of a safeguarding issue. In this section, a reference to the DSL means the DSL or a deputy DSL.

7.1 If a child is suffering or likely to suffer harm, or is in immediate danger

Make a referral to local authority children's social care and/or the police immediately if you believe a child is suffering or likely to suffer from harm, or is in immediate danger. Anyone can make a referral. For a Birmingham child, contact the Children's Advice and Support Service (CASS) on 0121 303 1888 (out of hours 0121 675 4806). For a child who lives in another local authority area, use that authority's children's services, and tell the DSL which route you used. In an emergency, call 999. Tell the DSL as soon as possible if you make a referral directly. You can also report child abuse to a local council through https://www.gov.uk/report-child-abuse-to-local-council Out of school hours, follow the out-of-hours protocol in Appendix 8.

7.2 If a child makes a disclosure to you

If a child discloses a safeguarding issue to you, you should:

- listen to and believe them. Allow them time to talk freely and do not ask leading questions. Where a pupil communicates in other ways, such as writing, drawing, signing, symbols or non-verbally, accept and record what they communicate in the way they communicate it
- stay calm and do not show that you are shocked or upset
- tell the child they have done the right thing in telling you. Do not tell them they should have told you sooner
- explain what will happen next and that you will have to pass this information on. Do not promise to keep it a secret
- write up your conversation as soon as possible in the child's own words. Stick to the facts, and do not put your own judgement on it
- sign and date the write-up and pass it to the DSL (record it on CPOMS, or on a Notice of Concern form if CPOMS is not available). Alternatively, if appropriate, make a referral directly (see 7.1) and tell the DSL as soon as possible. Aside from these people, do not disclose the information to anyone else unless told to do so by a relevant authority involved in the safeguarding process

Bear in mind that some children may not feel ready, or know how to tell someone that they are being abused, exploited or neglected; may not recognise their experiences as harmful; or may feel embarrassed, humiliated or threatened, which can be due to their vulnerability, disability, sexual orientation and/or language barriers. None of this should stop you having 'professional curiosity' and speaking to the DSL if you have concerns about a child.

7.3 If you discover that FGM has taken place or a pupil is at risk of FGM

KCSIE explains that FGM comprises 'all procedures involving partial or total removal of the external female genitalia, or other injury to the female genital organs'. FGM is illegal in the UK and a form of child abuse with long-lasting, harmful consequences. It is also known as 'female genital cutting', 'circumcision' or 'initiation'. Possible indicators are in Appendix 4.

Any teacher who is informed by a girl under 18 that an act of FGM has been carried out on her, or who observes physical signs which appear to show that an act of FGM has been carried out on a girl under 18 and has no reason to believe that the act was necessary for the girl's physical or mental health or for purposes connected with labour or birth, must immediately report this to the police, personally. This is a mandatory statutory duty, and teachers will face disciplinary sanctions for failing to meet it. Unless they have been specifically told not to, they should also discuss the case with the DSL and involve local authority children's social care as appropriate. Any other member of staff who discovers that an act of FGM appears to have been carried out on a pupil under 18 must speak to the DSL and follow our local safeguarding procedures.

The duty for teachers does not apply where a pupil is at risk of FGM or FGM is suspected but is not known to have been carried out. Staff should not examine pupils. Any member of staff who suspects a pupil is at risk of FGM, or suspects that FGM has been carried out, should speak to the DSL and follow our local safeguarding procedures, which are to consult CASS (0121 303 1888) and, where there is a risk of imminent harm, the police on 999.

7.4 If you have concerns about a child (as opposed to believing a child is suffering or likely to suffer harm, or is in immediate danger)

Where possible, speak to the DSL first to agree a course of action. If in exceptional circumstances the DSL and deputies are not available, this should not delay appropriate action. Speak to a member of the senior leadership team and/or take advice from CASS (0121 303 1888). You can also seek advice at any time from the NSPCC helpline on 0808 800 5000. Share details of any action you take with the DSL as soon as practically possible. Make a referral to local authority children's social care directly if appropriate (see 'Referral' below).

Safeguarding mailbox. You can also flag a concern in writing to the confidential safeguarding mailbox, using the subject line prefixes in Appendix 6. The mailbox is not monitored out of hours, so for anything urgent speak to the DSL or phone the school office. Do not use it to report a concern about the Head Teacher or the Proprietor (see Appendix 3).

The flow of a concern. Record the concern on CPOMS (or on a Notice of Concern form) and speak to the DSL. The DSL reviews the concern and decides the next steps using Birmingham's Right Help Right Time (RHRT) threshold guidance (see Appendix 9), considers discussing the concerns with parents or carers, and considers whether an Early Help Assessment (EHA) is needed. At any point the DSL can seek advice from CASS. The level of response then follows the child's need: Universal and Universal+ (early help, using the EHA, and a Family Connect Form where appropriate); Additional (early help with other agencies, using the EHA and consideration of a Family Connect Form or Request for Support); and Complex and Significant (a Request for Support submitted to CASS for a multi-agency strategy discussion).

Layers of need in Birmingham, adapted from Right Help, Right Time (version 7, June 2026). The full guidance is on the Birmingham Safeguarding Children Partnership website: Right Help, Right Time.

1. Universal needs	2. Universal Plus needs	3. Additional needs	4. Complex / Significant needs
All children have a right to a range of services. Professionals assess families to make sure that their general needs are met.	The child and family have needs that require support and interventions above and beyond normal universal services.	The child and family have needs that may require an intensive or substantial package of support, where these can be met without the need for statutory social work intervention.	The child's health and development may be impaired without the provision of services, or there is reasonable cause to suspect that the child is suffering, or likely to suffer, significant harm.
What we do: help the family to access appropriate local services.	What we do: talk to the child and family and seek consent. The DSL considers an Early Help Assessment and Our Family Plan, with a Family Connect Form where appropriate.	What we do: a lead professional co-ordinates a multi-agency plan. The DSL considers advice from CASS or an Early Help Conversation with the Early Help District Hub (Family Connect Form).	What we do: the DSL submits a Request for Support to CASS (0121 303 1888), unless the child is at immediate risk, when we call 999. Out of hours, call the Emergency Duty Team (0121 675 4806).

Consent and sharing information. We talk to the child and family and seek their consent before an early help offer or a referral to CASS, and we explain what we want to share, with whom and why. We do not seek consent where doing so would put the child at risk of harm. We do not need consent to share information where a child is at risk of, or we perceive a risk of, significant harm, because protecting a child takes priority over privacy. We share only what is necessary, proportionate, relevant, adequate and accurate, and only with those who have a role in safeguarding or supporting the child. The DSL records why information was shared or withheld. For pupils aged 13 to 16, the DSL considers whether the pupil understands enough to agree to help and services (Gillick competence).

Questions the DSL considers. When deciding on a level of need, the DSL asks: is the child vulnerable to, or experiencing, harm online; what protective factors are in the child's life; is the child suffering, or likely to suffer, significant harm; what have the child and family said; what are the family's strengths; and are risks increasing because the family is not engaging with agencies? The DSL also asks whether the child is likely to become out of sight of services, for example through permanent exclusion, no school place, home education or attendance of 50% or less, and whether a permanent exclusion would make the child more vulnerable.

Autistic pupils and mental health admission. A child who has a learning disability or is autistic, and who is in a tier 4 mental health hospital bed, is at risk of admission, is on the local Dynamic Support Register or receives Section 117 aftercare, is treated as having complex or significant needs. Where a pupil may be at risk of admission, the DSL asks for them to be identified on the Dynamic Support Register, with consent or a best interest decision as required.

Concerns that need a strategy discussion. The guidance requires a strategy discussion for suspected fabricated or induced illness, pregnancy or a sexually transmitted infection in a child under 13, and suspected concealment of drugs or money on the body. A police Threat to Life notice is also a complex or significant indicator. In each case the DSL contacts CASS at once.

Screening tools and required assessments. The DSL uses the screening tool that fits the concern, follows the Right Help, Right Time threshold guidance above to decide the level of need, and records the tool used and its outcome in CPOMS.

Exploitation. Where exploitation is a concern, including child criminal exploitation and child sexual exploitation, the DSL completes Birmingham's Combined Exploitation Screening Tool.

Neglect. Where neglect is a concern, the DSL completes the Neglect Screening Tool. For older pupils, the DSL uses the Adolescent Neglect Screening Tool, which comes with guidance.

Assessments children are entitled to. Some children are entitled to an assessment by children's services whatever their level of need, including young carers, privately fostered children (assessment within 7 working days), 16 and 17 year olds presenting as homeless, children receiving services under Section 117 of the Mental Health Act, and children with a disability. The DSL tells the local authority where we know of such a child. For Universal Plus needs, the Targeted Family Help Team can support the lead professional and family more intensively.

Professional disagreements. If we are concerned about how partners are handling a case, the DSL uses the Resolution and Escalation Protocol (November 2024) in the West Midlands Regional Child Protection Procedures, escalates through the levels set out in it, and records the outcome.

Early help assessment. If an early help assessment is appropriate, the DSL will generally lead on liaising with other agencies and setting up an inter-agency assessment, and the child's voice stays central. Staff may be required to support other agencies and professionals in an early help assessment, in some cases acting as the lead practitioner. The DSL keeps the case under constant review, and we consider a referral to local authority children's social care if the situation does not seem to be improving. Timelines of interventions are monitored and reviewed. For multi-agency early help, the DSL sets up an 'Our Family Plan'.

Referral. If it is appropriate to refer the case to local authority children's social care or the police, the DSL will make the referral or support you to do so (in Birmingham, through a Request for Support to CASS). If you make a referral directly, you must tell the DSL as soon as possible. The local authority should make a decision within 1 working day of a referral about what course of action to take and will let the person who made the referral know the outcome. The DSL or the person who made the referral must follow up with the local authority if this information is not provided, and make sure outcomes are properly recorded. If the child's situation does not seem to be improving after the referral, the DSL or the person who made the referral must follow the BSCP escalation procedures to make sure concerns are addressed and the child's situation improves. Where a child already has a social worker or family support worker, any escalation of risk is reported at once to them, or in their absence to their team manager.

7.5 If you have concerns about extremism

If a child is not suffering or likely to suffer harm, or in immediate danger, speak to the DSL first where possible to agree a course of action. If the DSL is not available, this should not delay action: speak to a member of the senior leadership team and/or seek advice from CASS, make a referral directly if appropriate, and inform the DSL or a deputy as soon as practically possible. Where there is a concern, the DSL will consider the level of risk and decide which agency to refer to. This could include the police, Channel (the government's programme for identifying and supporting individuals at risk of becoming involved with or supporting terrorism, led locally by the West Midlands Police Counter-Terrorism Unit) or children's social care. The DfE has a dedicated helpline, 020 7340 7264, which staff and members of the Board can call to raise concerns about extremism with respect to a pupil (email counter.extremism@education.gov.uk). It is not for emergencies. In an emergency, call 999 or the anti-terrorist hotline on 0800 789 321 if you think someone is in immediate danger, think someone may be planning to travel to join an extremist group, or see or hear something that may be terrorist-related. See our Preventing Extremism and Radicalisation Policy for our full approach.

7.6 If you have a concern about mental health

Mental health problems can, in some cases, be an indicator that a child has suffered or is at risk of suffering abuse, neglect or exploitation. They can also, in some cases, develop into safeguarding concerns, for example self-harm. Only appropriately trained professionals should attempt to make a diagnosis of a mental health problem. However, staff will be alert to behavioural signs that suggest a child may be experiencing a mental health problem or be at risk of developing one. If a child is struggling with their mental health, self-harming, has an eating disorder or is experiencing suicidal ideation and making plans to end their life, there are likely to be warning signs which education staff are well placed to recognise, including significant changes in behaviour, ongoing difficulty sleeping, withdrawing from social situations, not wanting to do things they usually like, and physical signs of self-harm or neglecting themselves.

If you have a mental health concern about a child that is also a safeguarding concern, take immediate action by following section 7.4. If you feel that a child is in danger, call 999 or arrange for the child to be taken to A&E immediately by their parent or another suitable person. If a child needs help urgently for their mental health but it is not an emergency, staff can get help from NHS 111 online or by calling 111 and selecting the mental health option. If you have a mental health concern that is not also a safeguarding concern, speak to the DSL to agree a course of action, and to our Lead for Mental Health, Kiana Gibson, who is supported by the senior leadership team. Our approach covers prevention, early identification, early support and access to specialist support, including through the child's EHC plan and external agencies such as CAMHS.

7.7 Concerns about a staff member, supply teacher, trainee teacher, volunteer or contractor

If an allegation is made about a member of staff (including a supply teacher, trainee teacher, volunteer or contractor) posing a risk of harm to children (meeting the harm threshold), speak to the Head Teacher without delay. If the allegation is about the Head Teacher, speak to the Chair of the School Governance Board, Mark O'Donnell. If it is about the Proprietor, report it directly to the LADO team.

If you have a low-level concern about a member of staff (a concern that does not meet the harm threshold), report it to the Head Teacher, who is our nominated person for low-level concerns. If the low-level concern is about the Head Teacher, report it to the Chair of the School Governance Board. The Head Teacher is the ultimate decision-maker for low-level concerns, but may choose to consult the Proprietor or the deputy DSLs and take a more collaborative decision. If, in future, a person other than the Head Teacher is nominated to receive low-level concerns, that person will always share the concern with the Head Teacher in a timely manner according to its nature.

Where you believe there is a conflict of interest in reporting a concern or allegation to the Head Teacher, report it directly to the LADO (0121 675 1669, ladoteam@birminghamchildrenstrust.co.uk). If you receive an allegation relating to an incident where an individual or organisation was using our premises to run an activity for children, follow our safeguarding policies and procedures, informing the LADO, as you would with any safeguarding allegation. Appendix 3 sets out the full procedures.

7.8 Allegations of abuse made against other pupils

We recognise that children are capable of abusing their peers. Abuse will never be tolerated or passed off as 'banter', 'just having a laugh', 'part of growing up' or 'boys being boys', as this can lead to a culture of unacceptable behaviours, misogyny and misandry, and an unsafe environment for pupils. For some, but not all, forms of child-on-child abuse it is more likely that girls will be victims and boys perpetrators. However, all child-on-child abuse is unacceptable and will be taken seriously.

Most cases of pupils hurting other pupils will be dealt with under our Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy and Anti-Bullying Policy, but this policy applies to any allegation that raises safeguarding concerns. This might include where the alleged behaviour is serious and potentially a criminal offence, could put pupils in the school at risk, is violent, involves pupils being forced to use drugs or alcohol, or involves sexual exploitation, sexual abuse or sexual harassment, such as indecent exposure, sexual assault, upskirting or sexually inappropriate pictures or videos (including the making or sharing of nudes and semi-nudes, including where generated by AI), which may include or be driven by misogyny or misandry. See Appendix 4 for more information.

If a pupil makes an allegation of abuse against another pupil:

- you must record the allegation and tell the DSL, but do not investigate it
- the DSL will contact children's social care (CASS) and follow its advice, as well as the police if the allegation involves a potential criminal offence
- the DSL will put a risk assessment and support plan in place for all children involved (the victim or victims, the child or children against whom the allegation has been made and any others affected), with a named person they can talk to if needed. This will include considering school transport as a potentially vulnerable place for a victim or alleged perpetrator
- the DSL will contact the child and adolescent mental health service (CAMHS) and other professionals already working with the pupils, where appropriate
- because our pupils have SEMH needs and autism, the DSL will consider each child's communication, understanding of social rules, sensory needs and past trauma, for both victim and alleged perpetrator, and will involve the pupil's key adult. This helps us respond fairly and does not excuse harm

If the incident is a criminal offence and there are delays in the criminal process, the DSL will work closely with the police (and other agencies as required) while protecting children and/or taking any disciplinary measures against the alleged perpetrator. We will ask the police if we have any questions about the investigation. The DSL will take the lead in any disciplining of the alleged perpetrator, and we will provide support at the same time as taking any disciplinary action. Disciplinary action can be taken while other investigations are going on, such as by the police. The fact that another body is investigating doesn't in itself prevent us from coming to our own conclusion about what happened and imposing a penalty accordingly. We consider these matters case by case, taking into account whether taking action would prejudice an investigation or prosecution (we liaise with the police and children's social care to determine this), and whether there are circumstances that make it unreasonable or irrational for us to reach our own view while an independent investigation is ongoing.

Creating a supportive environment and minimising the risk of child-on-child abuse. We take proactive action to minimise the risk of child-on-child abuse and to create an environment where victims feel confident in reporting incidents. We will:

- challenge any form of derogatory or sexualised language or inappropriate behaviour between peers, including requesting, making or sending sexual images
- be vigilant to issues that particularly affect different genders, for example sexualised or aggressive touching or grabbing towards female pupils, and initiation or hazing-type violence with respect to boys
- make sure our curriculum educates pupils about appropriate behaviour and consent
- make sure pupils can easily and confidently report abuse using our reporting systems (section 7.10)
- make sure staff reassure victims that they are being taken seriously
- be alert to reports of sexual violence and/or harassment that may point to environmental or systemic problems that could be addressed by updating policies, processes and the curriculum, or that could reflect wider issues in the local area to share with the safeguarding partners
- recognise the intersection of misogyny and misandry with harmful sexual behaviour. We will actively identify, challenge and address how misogynistic or misandrist attitudes contribute to the normalisation of inappropriate behaviour and increase the risk of child-on-child abuse, including sexual harassment and sexual violence
- be alert to the prevalence of harmful online material and extreme misogynistic or misandrist ideologies, including misogynistic influencers, and the impact this content could have on pupils' attitudes
- support children who have witnessed sexual violence, especially rape or assault by penetration, and do all we can to make sure the victim, alleged perpetrator(s) and any witnesses are not bullied or harassed
- consider intra-familial harms and any necessary support for siblings following a report of sexual violence or harassment

We make sure that staff are trained to understand how to recognise the indicators and signs of child-on-child abuse and respond to reports; that even if there are no reports of child-on-child abuse in school, it does not mean it is not happening, so staff keep an attitude of 'it could happen here'; that if they have any concern about a child's welfare they should act on it immediately rather than wait to be told, because victims may not make a direct report (children can show signs or act in ways they hope adults will notice, a friend may make a report, a member of staff may overhear a conversation, or a child's behaviour might show that something is wrong); that certain children may face additional barriers to telling someone because of their vulnerability, disability, gender, ethnicity and/or sexual orientation; that a pupil harming a peer could be a sign that the child is being abused themselves, which falls within the scope of this policy; that social media is likely to play a role in the fall-out from any incident, including contact between the victim, alleged perpetrator(s) and friends from either side; and that exposure to misogynistic or misandrist content online can indicate a safeguarding concern and needs early discussion with the DSL.

Unsubstantiated, unfounded, false or malicious reports. If a report is determined to be unsubstantiated, unfounded, false or malicious, the DSL will consider whether the child and/or the person who made the report is in need of help, or has been abused by someone else, or whether the report may have been a cry for help. In such circumstances a referral to children's social care may be appropriate. If a report is shown to be deliberately false or malicious, we will consider whether any disciplinary action is appropriate against the

individual or individuals who made it, in line with our Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy.

7.9 Making or sharing of nudes and semi-nudes

This approach is based on guidance from the UK Council for Internet Safety and the Department for Science, Innovation and Technology. All incidents involving the sharing of nude or semi-nude images, whether consensual or non-consensual, require a safeguarding response. If you are made aware of an incident involving the consensual or non-consensual making or sharing of nudes or semi-nudes, including where generated by AI, you must report it to the DSL immediately.

You must not: view, copy, print, share, store or save the imagery yourself, or ask a pupil to share or download it (if you have already viewed it by accident, tell the DSL); delete the imagery or ask the pupil to delete it; ask the pupil or pupils involved to disclose information about the imagery (this is the DSL's job); share information about the incident with other members of staff, the pupils involved or their, or other, parents and carers; or say or do anything to blame or shame any young person involved. You should explain that you need to report the incident, and reassure the pupil that they will receive support and help from the DSL.

Initial review meeting. Following a report, the DSL will hold an initial review meeting with appropriate staff. It will consider the initial evidence and aim to decide whether there is an immediate risk to any pupil; whether a referral needs to be made to the police and/or children's social care; whether it is necessary to view the images in order to safeguard the young person (in most cases images should not be viewed); what further information is needed; whether the images have been shared widely and on what services or platforms; whether to take immediate action to delete or remove images from devices or online services; any relevant facts about the pupils involved which would influence risk assessment; whether another school, setting or individual needs to be contacted; and whether to contact parents or carers (in most cases they should be involved).

The DSL will make an immediate referral to the police and/or children's social care if: the incident involves an adult (an adult may pose as a child to groom or exploit a child, so the incident may first look like a child-on-child incident, see Appendix 4); there is reason to believe a young person has been coerced, blackmailed or groomed, or there are concerns about their capacity to consent (for example, owing to SEND, which is a particular consideration at our school); what the DSL knows about the images suggests sexual acts which are unusual for the young person's developmental stage, or are violent; the imagery involves sexual acts and any pupil in it is under 13; or the DSL has reason to believe a pupil is at immediate risk of harm owing to the incident (for example, they are presenting as suicidal or self-harming). If none of these apply, the DSL, in consultation with the Head Teacher where appropriate, may decide to respond without involving the police or children's social care. The decision will be made and recorded in line with this policy.

If a decision is made not to refer at the initial review, the DSL will conduct a further review to establish the facts and assess the risks, and will hold interviews with the pupils involved if appropriate. If at any point there is a concern that a pupil has been harmed or is at risk of harm, a referral will be made immediately. The DSL will inform parents and carers at an early stage and keep them involved, unless there is good reason to believe that this would put the pupil at risk of harm. If it is necessary to refer an incident to the police, this is done through

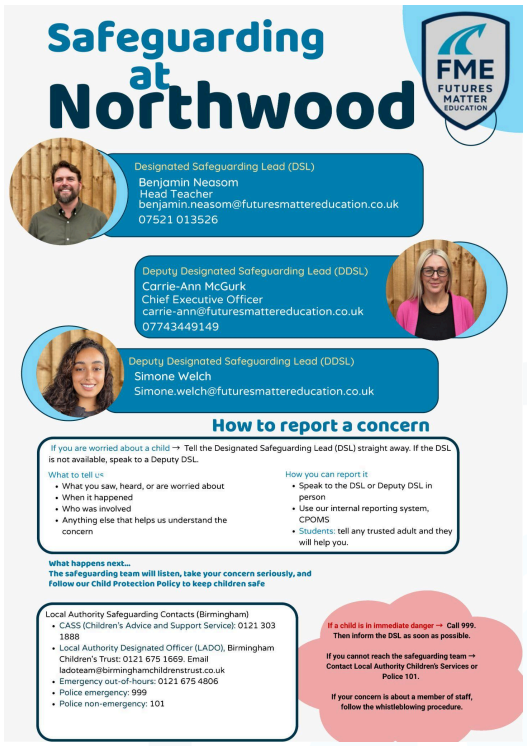
West Midlands Police by dialling 101 (or 999 where there is immediate risk). All incidents, and the decisions made in responding to them, are recorded on CPOMS.

Pupils are taught about the issues surrounding the making or sharing of nudes and semi-nudes through our RSHE programme and online safety teaching: what it is, how it is most likely to be encountered, the consequences of requesting, forwarding or providing such images (including when it is and is not abusive, and when it may be online sexual harassment, including images made using AI), issues of legality, the risk of damage to people's feelings and reputation, and the skills to manage requests or pressure to make, provide or forward images and to manage the receipt of such images. Teaching puts safeguarding first, approaches the issue from the child's perspective, promotes dialogue and understanding, empowers children, never frightens or scare-mongers, and challenges victim-blaming attitudes. This policy is shared with pupils, in an accessible form, so they know the process we follow.

7.10 Reporting systems for our pupils

Where there is a safeguarding concern, we take the child's wishes and feelings into account when deciding what action to take and what services to provide. We recognise the importance of pupils feeling safe and comfortable to come forward and report concerns or allegations. To achieve this, we will put systems in place for pupils to confidently report abuse; make sure our reporting systems are well promoted, easily understood and easily accessible; and make it clear that concerns will be taken seriously and that pupils can safely express their views and give feedback.

At Futures Matter - Northwood, every pupil has trusted adults in school, including a key adult, and pupils can tell any member of staff. Staff are trained to listen in the way each pupil communicates, including pupils who are non-verbal or find it hard to talk. Pupils learn about who to tell and how, through RSHE, assemblies and key adult sessions, and we remind them who the DSL and deputy DSLs are. Pupils are reassured after any disclosure about what will happen next and who will support them. Pupils can also use Childline (0800 1111) and, for online concerns, the UK Safer Internet Centre and CEOP. Pupils have access to a confidential worry box which is monitored by Simone Welch as both DDSL and Mental Health Lead. The poster below is displayed around the school and in all toilet cubicles:





Staff, Visitors, Student Safeguarding Poster	Pupil centered Safeguarding Poster

7.11 Reporting a concern if you do not use CPOMS or email (cleaners, contractors and other adults)

Safeguarding is everyone's responsibility. This includes cleaners, caretakers, catering and maintenance staff, contractors, agency workers, volunteers and any other adult who works on our premises, during the school day or out of school hours. These adults may see or hear something that worries them about a child, or about how an adult behaves, and they do not need CPOMS, email or a school login to report it. A concern can always be raised by speaking to someone. Writing it down helps, but it is never a condition of being listened to.

What to do. Tell the DSL or a deputy DSL at once, in person or by phoning the school on 0121 835 1360 during school hours. If none of them is on site, tell the most senior member of staff there, who will find the DSL. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999. Listen, reassure and pass it on. Do not question a child, investigate, confront anyone or promise to keep a secret, and do not take photographs or screenshots of anything involving a child.

Offline concern card. The offline concern card (Appendix 7) is a paper form that can be completed by hand. Cards are kept in the school office, the cleaners' store and the staffroom. Write what you saw or heard, in your own words, and give the card to the DSL or a deputy in person. If none of them is on site, put the card in the locked safeguarding concerns box in the school office and phone the school to say a card has been left. The DSL or a deputy empties the box at the start and end of every school day. Do not leave a card on a desk, ask a colleague to pass it on or photograph it. Locked postbox in reception area.

Out of school hours. Anyone working when the school is closed should call 999 if a child is in immediate danger. For anything else, complete a card, put it in the locked box, and tell the

DSL on the next school day. If a concern is urgent but is not an emergency, phone the Children's Advice and Support Service on 0121 303 1888 (out of hours 0121 675 4806) and tell the DSL as soon as the school is open.

Concerns about an adult. Tell the Head Teacher. If the concern is about the Head Teacher, tell the Chair of the School Governance Board, Mark O'Donnell. If it is about the Proprietor, phone the LADO team on 0121 675 1669. Do not put a concern about the Head Teacher or the Proprietor in the locked box, because the DSL empties it. Put it in a sealed envelope marked 'Private: Chair of the School Governance Board' and give it to the Chair, or phone the LADO team. The Chair can also be contacted directly at c.o.g@futuresmattereducation.co.uk.

Language support. Anyone who finds it hard to read or write in English can write the card in their own language, tell someone and ask them to write it down, or ask for an interpreter. Part 1 of Keeping Children Safe in Education, which every adult on site should read, is available in many community languages: Keeping Children Safe in Education Part 1 Translations (LGFL).

Briefing and reminders. Every cleaner, contractor and agency worker has a short safeguarding briefing before they start work, covering who the DSL and deputy DSLs are, what to do, and how to use the card. They sign to confirm they understand it, and the Head Teacher keeps the record. A poster with the names, photographs and contact details of the DSL and deputy DSLs is displayed in staff areas, including the cleaners' store.

What happens next. The DSL records the concern on CPOMS on the day it is received, tells the person who raised it that it has been received, and keeps the card with the record in line with our records retention schedule. We thank and protect anyone who raises a concern in good faith, whether or not it turns out to be right.

8.0 ONLINE SAFETY AND THE USE OF MOBILE TECHNOLOGY

We recognise the importance of safeguarding children from potentially harmful and inappropriate online material, and we understand that technology is a significant component in many safeguarding and wellbeing issues. Our pupils may be especially exposed online because of their social communication needs, and some spend a lot of time online outside school. To address this, we aim to:

- have robust processes, including filtering and monitoring systems, to make sure the online safety of pupils, staff, volunteers and members of the Board
- protect and educate the whole school community in the safe and responsible use of technology, including mobile and smart technology (which we call 'mobile phones')
- set clear guidelines for the use of mobile phones for the whole school community, including the expectation that our school is a mobile phone-free environment by default
- establish clear mechanisms to identify, intervene in and escalate any incidents or concerns where appropriate

The 4 key categories of risk. Our approach to online safety is based on addressing:

- **Content:** being exposed to illegal, inappropriate or harmful content, such as pornography, racism, misogyny, self-harm, suicide, antisemitism, radicalisation,

extremism, extreme sexual or physical violence, misinformation, disinformation (including fake news) and conspiracy theories

- **Contact:** being subjected to harmful online interaction with other users or with generative AI applications that simulate this, such as peer-to-peer pressure, commercial advertising, and adults posing as children or young adults with the intention to groom or exploit them for sexual, criminal, financial or other purposes
- **Conduct:** online behaviour that increases the likelihood of, or causes, harm, such as making, sending and receiving explicit images (including those generated using AI) and online bullying
- **Commerce:** risks such as online gambling, inappropriate advertising, phishing and financial scams

To meet our aims and address these risks, we will:

- educate pupils about online safety as part of our curriculum, including the safe use of social media, the internet and technology, keeping personal information private, recognising unacceptable behaviour online, and how to report cyberbullying, including as a witness rather than a victim. We teach this in ways that suit pupils with autism, for example with concrete examples and rehearsed scripts
- train staff, as part of their induction, on safe internet use and online safeguarding issues, including cyberbullying, the risks of online radicalisation, and the expectations, roles and responsibilities around filtering and monitoring. Staff receive refresher training as required, and at least once each academic year
- educate parents and carers about online safety through our website, direct communications and at reviews and meetings, and share clear procedures so they know how to raise concerns about online safety
- make sure staff know the restrictions on their own use of mobile phones and cameras. Staff may bring personal phones to school for their own use but limit that use to non-contact time when pupils are not present, and will not take pictures or recordings of pupils on their personal phones or cameras
- make sure pupils, parents and carers, staff, volunteers and members of the Board are aware that they are expected to follow our acceptable use agreement for the internet, our ICT systems and mobile and smart technology
- explain the sanctions we use if a pupil breaches our policies on acceptable use of the internet and mobile phones
- make sure staff, pupils and parents and carers know that staff have the power to search pupils' phones, as set out in the DfE's guidance on searching, screening and confiscation
- operate robust filtering and monitoring systems (Senso, a provider accredited under the UK Safer Internet Centre filtering accreditation scheme, which integrates with CPOMS and has image blur and assisted monitoring enabled) to limit children's exposure to the 4 key categories of risk from our IT systems, with filtering and monitoring requirements also applying to our use of generative AI (see our Filtering and Monitoring Policy and Online Safety Policy)
- carry out an annual review of our approach to online safety, supported by an annual risk assessment that reflects the risks faced by our school community

- carry out an annual review of our filtering and monitoring effectiveness, led by the senior leader responsible for filtering and monitoring with the support of the DSL and IT support; **Benjamin Neasom, Headteacher is responsible and accountable for Filtering & Monitoring which is a standing item on Governance Board meetings.**

Mobile phone-free by default. Our school is a mobile phone-free environment by default. Pupils do not use mobile phones during the school day, and our arrangements for handing in, storing and returning phones, and for any exceptions (for example, a medical or other agreed need), are set out in our Mobile Phone Policy and in our Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy. This section summarises our approach. For full details see our Online Safety Policy, Filtering and Monitoring Policy and Mobile Phone Policy.

8.1 Artificial intelligence (AI)

Generative AI tools are now widespread and easy to access. We recognise that AI has many uses, including enhancing teaching and learning, and helping to protect and safeguard pupils. However, AI may also have the potential to facilitate abuse (for example bullying and grooming) and/or expose pupils to harmful content, for example 'deepfakes', where AI is used to create images, audio or video hoaxes that look real. We treat any use of AI to access harmful content or bully pupils in line with this policy and our Anti-Bullying and Behaviour policies. Staff should be aware of the risks of using AI tools while they are still being developed, and carry out a risk assessment for any new AI tool used by the school. Our filtering and monitoring requirements also apply to the use of AI, in line with KCSIE.

Safeguarding considerations include: inappropriate, harmful or inaccurate content; AI-generated nudes and semi-nudes; pupils sharing personal or sensitive information with AI tools; grooming and impersonation of trusted adults or peers; and misinformation. Pupils' use of generative AI is supervised and monitored. Staff are trained to recognise the risks. Pupils are taught that creating, sharing or possessing AI-generated sexual images of children is illegal. Any incident involving AI-generated harmful content is treated as a safeguarding concern and reported to the DSL immediately, following section 7.9 where nude or semi-nude images are involved. Parents and carers are told about our approach.

AI companions, scams and image misuse. Pupils may form emotional attachments to AI chatbots or 'companions', share personal information with them, or be impersonated through cloned voices and faces. Staff are alert to pupils who rely emotionally on AI, who are asked for new images or audio, or who are being pressured or blackmailed. Online scams and fraud, including phishing, impersonation and requests to receive or move money (which can be a sign of criminal exploitation), are covered in our online safety teaching, and pupils are taught to stop, think and verify before acting. Indecent images of children are reported to the Internet Watch Foundation, online sexual exploitation can be reported to CEOP, and pupils can use Report Remove (Childline and the IWF) to ask for a nude image of themselves to be taken down. The DSL decides on any report, and staff never deal with these concerns alone. Before any new AI tool is used with pupils, we also complete a data protection impact assessment. For advice for pupils, parents and staff on staying safe online, see Kids Online World.

9.0 NOTIFYING PARENTS OR CARERS

Where appropriate, we will discuss any concerns about a child with the child's parents or carers. The DSL will normally do this in the event of a suspicion or disclosure. Other staff will

only talk to parents or carers about any such concerns following consultation with the DSL. If we believe that notifying the parents or carers would increase the risk to the child, we will discuss this with local authority children's social care before doing so. Where a child is placed by a local authority, we also keep the placing authority informed in line with our agreements.

In the case of allegations of abuse made against other children, we will normally notify the parents or carers of all the children involved. We will think carefully about what information we provide about the other child involved, and when, and work with the police and/or children's social care so that our approach to information sharing is consistent. The DSL will, with any relevant agencies (decided case by case), meet the victim's parents or carers, with the victim, to discuss what is being put in place to safeguard them and what support they may need, and meet the alleged perpetrator's parents or carers to discuss the support for them and what is being put in place that will affect them, and the reasons for any decision.

We inform parents and carers about this policy through our website and when their child joins the school. We will not disclose to a parent any information held on a child if this would put the child at risk of significant harm.

10.0 PUPILS WITH SEND, DISABILITIES OR HEALTH ISSUES

We recognise that pupils with SEND or certain health conditions can face additional safeguarding challenges, both online and offline. Children with disabilities are more likely to be abused than their peers. Additional barriers can exist when recognising abuse, exploitation and neglect in this group, including:

- assumptions that indicators of possible abuse, such as behaviour, mood and injury, relate to the child's condition without further exploration
- pupils being more prone to peer group isolation or bullying (including prejudice-based bullying) than other pupils
- the potential for pupils with SEN, disabilities or certain health conditions to be disproportionately affected by behaviours such as bullying, without outwardly showing any signs
- communication barriers, and difficulties in managing or reporting these challenges, so that a child may not understand that what is happening to them is abuse
- the need for intimate care, or these children being isolated from others
- these children being more likely to depend on adults for care
- cognitive understanding: being unable to tell the difference between fact and fiction in online content and then repeating the content or behaviours in school, or being unable to understand the consequences of doing so

All of our pupils have SEND and the majority of pupils have EHC plans, so we treat each pupil as potentially more vulnerable, and our whole approach is built around this. Our extra pastoral support includes a key adult for every pupil, communication that suits each pupil (including visual supports, extra time and non-verbal routes), emotional regulation and Thrive-informed support led by trained staff, individual behaviour support plans and risk assessments shared with parents and carers, and access to our Lead for Mental Health. Any abuse involving pupils with SEND requires close liaison between the DSL (or a deputy) and the SENCO (currently SENCO role is held by Benjamin Neasom Headteacher until a SENCO is appointed), and we make sure appropriate support for communication is in place.

Reasonable force and restrictive interventions. We cannot and will not have a 'no contact' policy, because it would leave staff unable to fully support and protect pupils. Staff are trained in GCM (Global Conflict Management) therapeutic de-escalation and physical intervention, which is a last resort to keep pupils safe from harm, prevent harm to others, or prevent serious damage to property. We plan positive and proactive behaviour support so that the need for force reduces, and we write individual plans and risk assessments for more vulnerable pupils. See our Restrictive Interventions Policy.

When we consider a suspension of a pupil, the Head Teacher considers all known risks and consults the Proprietor or the Chair of the School Governance Board. Before any permanent exclusion of a pupil who has a child protection plan or an existing child protection file, we carry out a holistic multi-agency risk assessment.

11.0 PUPILS WITH MEDICAL CONDITIONS

An incident relating to the management of a child's medical condition (including allergies) does not in itself warrant a referral to the safeguarding partners. A safeguarding referral will be made where an incident highlights a concern that the child might be at increased risk of being neglected, abused or exploited by persons inside or outside their family because of their medical condition. For example, information about the child's medical condition might be withheld from the school, or the child may repeatedly be sent to school without essential medication, putting them at risk. Signs or behaviours that might otherwise indicate abuse or neglect are not automatically attributed to a medical condition. Staff keep professional curiosity and talk to the DSL. We keep individual healthcare plans in line with our Supporting Pupils with Medical Conditions Policy.

12.0 YOUNG CARERS

We recognise that caring responsibilities can affect a child's attendance, attainment, behaviour and wellbeing, and that early identification is essential so that young carers get support at the right time and from the right services, including extra support from external partners, the local authority and health services. Where we identify a young carer, the DSL and the pupil's key adult work with the family and, where appropriate, the local young carers' service.

13.0 PUPILS WITH A SOCIAL WORKER

Pupils may need a social worker due to safeguarding or welfare needs. We recognise that a child's experiences of adversity and trauma can leave them vulnerable to further harm, and can create barriers to attendance, learning, behaviour and mental health. The DSL and all staff work with and support social workers to help protect vulnerable children. Where we know that a pupil has a social worker, the DSL will always consider this fact so that decisions are made in the best interests of the pupil's safety, welfare and educational outcomes, for example when deciding how to respond to unauthorised absence or missing education where there are known safeguarding risks, and what pastoral and/or academic support to provide.

14.0 LOOKED-AFTER CHILDREN

We make sure staff have the skills, knowledge and understanding to keep looked-after and previously looked-after children safe. In particular:

- appropriate staff have relevant information about children's looked-after legal status, contact arrangements with birth parents or those with parental responsibility, and care arrangements
- the DSL has details of the child's local authority social worker and the relevant virtual school head, and of the Birmingham Children's Trust personal adviser for any care leaver

We have appointed a designated teacher, Benjamin Neasom, who is responsible for promoting the educational achievement of looked-after and previously looked-after children, in line with statutory guidance. The designated teacher is appropriately trained and has the relevant qualifications and experience to perform the role. The designated teacher will work closely with the DSL so that any safeguarding concern about a looked-after or previously looked-after child is quickly and effectively responded to, and will work with virtual school heads to promote educational achievement, including discussing how pupil premium plus funding can best be used to meet the needs in the child's personal education plan (PEP).

15.0 PUPILS WHO ARE LESBIAN, GAY OR BISEXUAL

We recognise that a child being lesbian, gay or bisexual is not in itself a risk factor for harm. However, pupils who are (or who are perceived by other children to be) lesbian, gay or bisexual can sometimes be vulnerable to discriminatory bullying. See our Anti-Bullying Policy and Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy for how we prevent bullying based on sexuality. Any concerns should be reported to the DSL. Pupils can speak to their key adult or to any trusted adult, and staff provide a safe space for pupils to share their concerns.

16.0 PUPILS WHO ARE QUESTIONING THEIR GENDER

16.1 Supporting pupils who are questioning their gender. We are aware of the potential vulnerabilities of children who are questioning their gender, including the possibility of complex mental health and psychosocial needs, such as relating to relationships with family, peers or their broader social environment. We take a strong, proactive stance on all forms of bullying based on gender (see our Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy and Anti-Bullying Policy). We will make sure children and their families know that, while we will appropriately sanction any bullying or harassment and take a strong stand against it, we must also be conscious of the rights of pupils and staff in relation to their religion or belief. When supporting a pupil who is questioning their gender, we take into account the principle of taking a careful approach. The DSL leads in these cases.

16.2 Involving parents and carers. Where a child who is questioning their gender asks for support from the school, we will engage parents and carers as a matter of priority. In the rare circumstances where involving parents or carers might put a pupil at greater risk than not involving them, the DSL will decide what is needed to safeguard the child before contacting parents or carers or taking any decisions. Where a child confides in a member of staff about their feelings but does not ask the school to change how they are treated, we will only break the confidence if there is a related safeguarding risk.

16.3 Requests for support with social transition. We will not initiate any action regarding social transition. When a pupil or their parent or carer asks us to make changes or put support in place so that the pupil presents as the opposite biological sex ('social transition'), we will work together with parents and carers to decide what is in the best interests of the child and of other children. Staff will not adopt any changes relating to social transition unless a decision has been made by the school and the child's parents or carers have been

involved, as set out in KCSIE. In making decisions we comply with our obligations under safeguarding legislation and equality and human rights law, and any assessment of discrimination is informed by our evaluation of the welfare and best interests of the child and other children. We follow these principles:

- we have statutory duties to safeguard and promote the welfare of all children. The first step is to consider what is in the best interests of the child and other children, and a decision about social transition may not be the same as the child's wishes
- parents and carers should be actively involved and their views treated with importance. Except in the rare circumstances where involving them would be a greater risk to the child than not involving them, they are engaged as a matter of priority and their views carry great weight
- accommodating social transition is an active intervention that may have significant effects on the child's psychological functioning and longer-term outcomes, so we take a very careful approach
- we comply with our obligations under the Equality Act 2010 and the Human Rights Act 1998

The decision-making process is documented and records are kept. A child's circumstances or needs may change, so we may need to review the original decision, and we involve the DSL in doing so.

16.4 Single-sex spaces. Pupils are not allowed into toilets, changing rooms or showers designated for the opposite biological sex, with no exceptions.

16.5 Single-sex sports. We may teach and play some sports, games or competitive activities in single-sex groups where the physical strength, stamina or physique of the average girl would put her at a disadvantage in competition with the average boy (or the other way round). We can separate children according to their biological sex in these circumstances. Some sports may need to be played in single-sex groups from a certain age to ensure children's safety. Where single-sex sports are used for safety reasons, there are no exceptions and pupils must not take part in sports designed for the opposite sex.

17.0 COMPLAINTS AND CONCERNS ABOUT SAFEGUARDING

17.1 Complaints against staff. Complaints against staff that are likely to require a child protection investigation will be handled in accordance with our procedures for dealing with allegations of abuse against staff (Appendix 3).

17.2 Other complaints. Other safeguarding-related complaints, for example about pupils, premises or how we have handled a concern, are handled under our Complaints Policy. A parent, carer or pupil who is concerned that we have not followed this policy can raise it with the Head Teacher, or with the Chair of the School Governance Board if it concerns the Head Teacher. Where the complaint raises a safeguarding concern, the DSL will deal with that concern first and in line with this policy, whatever the stage of the complaint.

17.3 Whistleblowing. We are committed to a culture where staff feel able to raise concerns about the conduct of colleagues or our practice, without fear of victimisation. Whistleblowing is when a member of staff, volunteer, contractor or member of the Board raises a genuine concern about wrongdoing, risk or malpractice that affects others, such as pupils, colleagues or the school, rather than a personal grievance. Our full procedure is set out in the Whistleblowing Policy (FME-SG-10), and this section is a summary that should be read with

it. It covers, for example, a safeguarding concern including poor or unsafe safeguarding practice, financial irregularity, a health and safety breach that puts people at risk, a criminal offence or the covering up of one, and a failure to comply with a legal or regulatory obligation.

- **Who to tell.** Raise a concern with the Head Teacher. If the concern is about the Head Teacher, or you believe he may be involved, go to the Proprietor (Carrie-Ann McGurk), and then to the Chair of the School Governance Board (Mark O'Donnell) if the concern involves the Proprietor or has not been resolved. You can go to the Proprietor or the Chair at any time if you do not feel able to raise it with the Head Teacher. You can go to an external body if the concern is serious, has not been addressed internally, or you reasonably believe it would not be dealt with properly if raised internally
- **How.** A concern can be raised verbally or in writing. We ask staff to give their name where they can, as it makes investigation easier, but an anonymous concern will still be considered
- **External contacts.** The Futures Matter directors or the Chair of the Board; the Birmingham LADO team on 0121 675 1669; the Ofsted whistleblowing line on 0300 123 3155; the NSPCC whistleblowing helpline on 0800 028 0285; and the police where a concern involves a criminal offence. These details are displayed on the premises and shared at induction
- **How we respond.** The person who receives the concern will acknowledge it, decide what kind of concern it is (including whether it is a safeguarding allegation under Appendix 3), and decide who is best placed to look into it. Where possible we tell the person who raised it the outcome, within the limits of confidentiality. A concern about the Head Teacher goes to the Proprietor, who can escalate it to the Chair of the Board. A concern about the Proprietor goes to the Chair of the Board, or directly to the LADO team if it is a safeguarding allegation. Where a concern about the Head Teacher is an allegation that meets the harm threshold, the Proprietor makes sure the Chair, who acts as case manager under Appendix 3, and the LADO are told without delay
- **Protection.** We will not tolerate victimisation of anyone who raises a genuine concern in good faith, even if it turns out to be mistaken. Staff are protected from detriment or dismissal under the Public Interest Disclosure Act 1998. Concerns are handled confidentially wherever possible. A report that is known to be false, or made maliciously, is not protected and is treated as a disciplinary matter

A concern about a member of staff, a member of the Board or a volunteer that meets the harm threshold is a safeguarding allegation and follows Appendix 3, in addition to or instead of the whistleblowing route.

18.0 RECORD-KEEPING

We hold records in line with our records retention schedule which is held in the confidential area on our SLT drive. All safeguarding concerns, discussions, decisions made and the reasons for those decisions must be recorded in writing, including where referrals were or were not made to another agency such as children's social care or the Prevent programme. If you are in any doubt about whether to record something, discuss it with the DSL. Records include a clear and comprehensive summary of the concern, details of how it was followed up and resolved, and a note of any action taken, decisions reached and the outcome.

What a good record includes. Records are factual, in date order and written in plain language. They include who is recording and when; the pupil's legal name and date of birth; the date, time and place of what happened; how, and by whom, the concern was raised; a factual description with the exact words used; anyone else involved or present; a body map where an injury is seen, disclosed or suspected; and what was done and why. Staff avoid jargon, assumptions and emotive language, and keep what they saw or heard separate from what they believe. Where the DSL records an assessment of risk, they use clear probability words: very unlikely, possible, suspected, likely or almost certain. Records are passed to the DSL as soon as possible.

We keep safeguarding records electronically on CPOMS, in a separate child protection file for each child, accessed only by those who need to see it. We do not hold paper files. We do not keep family files. Records are kept securely, in line with our Data Protection Policy and Privacy Notices, and files are kept for at least the time the child is on roll and afterwards for a reasonable period in line with current data legislation and guidance. Staff are told relevant details only when the DSL judges that knowing them will improve their ability to support the child, and a record is made of what was shared, with whom and when.

If a child for whom we have, or have had, safeguarding concerns moves to another school, the DSL will make sure their child protection file is transferred as soon as possible, securely, and separately from the main pupil file, and in any case within 5 days for an in-year transfer, or within the first 5 days of the start of a new term. We record where and to whom the records have been passed and the date. If the concerns are significant or complex, and/or children's social care is involved, the DSL will also speak to the DSL of the receiving school and give them the information they need to prepare to keep the child safe, which can be before the child leaves.

In addition, Appendix 2 sets out our record-keeping for recruitment and pre-appointment checks, and Appendix 3 sets out record-keeping for allegations against staff.

19.0 TRAINING

19.1 All staff. All staff undertake safeguarding and child protection training at induction, including whistleblowing procedures and online safety, so that they understand our safeguarding systems and their responsibilities and can identify signs of possible abuse, exploitation or neglect. The training is regularly updated and will be integrated, aligned and considered as part of our whole-school safeguarding approach and wider staff training; in line with advice from the 3 safeguarding partners; include online safety, including the expectations, roles and responsibilities for staff around filtering and monitoring; and have regard to the Teachers' Standards, which expect all teachers to manage behaviour effectively to ensure a good and safe environment and to have a clear understanding of the needs of all pupils. All staff also have training on the government's Prevent strategy to help them identify children at risk of becoming involved with or supporting terrorism and challenge extremist ideas. Staff receive regular safeguarding and child protection updates, including on online safety, as required and at least annually (for example through emails, bulletins, staff meetings and our daily briefings). Contractors and trainee teachers who work with our pupils are made aware of our arrangements and their responsibilities. We do not use volunteers in our school; if we ever do, they will receive appropriate training. Staff and other adults who speak English as an additional language can read Part 1 of Keeping Children Safe in Education in community languages: Keeping Children Safe in Education Part 1 Translations

(LGFL). All cleaners, caretakers and contractors on site receive Part 1 or a plain-language summary of it (see section 7.11).

19.2 The DSL and deputy DSLs. The DSL and both deputy DSLs undertake child protection and safeguarding training at least every 2 years. They also update their knowledge and skills at regular intervals, and at least annually, for example through e-bulletins, meeting other DSLs (including Birmingham City Council's monthly DSL case-consultation sessions) or reading and digesting safeguarding developments. They, and the Prevent lead, also undertake more in-depth Prevent awareness training, including on extremist and terrorist ideologies.

19.3 Members of the School Governance Board and the Proprietor. All members of the Board and the Proprietor receive training about safeguarding and child protection, including online safety, at induction, and it is regularly updated, so that they have the knowledge and information to perform their functions and understand their responsibilities, such as providing strategic challenge, and can be assured that our safeguarding policies and procedures are effective and support a robust whole-school approach. As the Chair of the Board acts as the case manager if an allegation is made against the Head Teacher, the Chair receives training in managing allegations for this purpose.

19.4 Recruitment and interview panels. At least one person on every interview panel has completed safer recruitment training, covering at least the content of KCSIE and in line with local safeguarding procedures. See Appendix 2.

19.5 Staff who have contact with pupils and families. All staff who have contact with children and families have supervision that provides support, coaching and training, promotes the interests of children, and allows confidential discussion of sensitive issues. DSLs are offered regular safeguarding supervision, and staff are supported through de-briefs, our daily morning briefing and whole-school de-brief, and one-to-one reflective practice with a line manager, as set out in our Staff Supervision Policy.

20.0 MONITORING ARRANGEMENTS

This policy is reviewed at least annually by the Head Teacher, with the deputy DSLs, and approved by the School Governance Board at every review. It is published on our website, is provided to all staff and explained at induction, and a copy of, or link to, it is included in application packs for jobs at our school. The DSL makes sure all staff, especially new and part-time staff, have access to it and understand it.

Quality assurance. We check that our safeguarding arrangements work, using a quality assurance framework that asks: how much did we do; how well did we do it; are there opportunities to learn and improve; and is anyone better off. This includes file and themed audits, pupil, parent, carer and partner feedback, Birmingham's Section 175 audit where it applies to us, an annual safeguarding report to the Board that includes the number of early help interventions, requests for support made and requests accepted, and external checks. We take part in multi-agency audits where invited.

Learning from reviews. The DSL updates all staff at least annually about the relevant outcomes and findings of local and national Child Safeguarding Practice Reviews, Domestic Homicide Reviews and Lessons Learnt Reviews. Where a case is relevant to us, we fully support the review with all necessary information, share information with the Birmingham Safeguarding Children Partnership and put the resulting actions and learning into practice.

Governance and inspection readiness. The DSL gives the School Governance Board a safeguarding report at least once each term, and safeguarding is a standing item at every Board meeting. The Head Teacher audits the Single Central Record at least every term, including contractors, members of the Board and volunteers, and checks that safeguarding logs are clear, in date order and show follow-up and outcomes. Staff at every level are able to explain who the DSL and deputy DSLs are, how to report a concern and how to escalate it. **The Board meets half termly chaired by Mark O'Donnell.**

21.0 LINKS WITH OTHER POLICIES

This policy links to the following policies and procedures:

- Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy and Anti-Bullying Policy
- Staff Code of Conduct, Staff Supervision Policy and Whistleblowing Policy (see also section 17.3)
- Complaints Policy
- Health and Safety Policy, First Aid Policy and Supporting Pupils with Medical Conditions Policy
- Attendance Policy, and Children Missing Education and Missing Pupils Policy
- Online Safety Policy, Filtering and Monitoring Policy, Acceptable Use Policy and Mobile Phone Policy
- Cyber Security Policy and Response Plan
- Equality, Diversity and Inclusion Policy and Accessibility Plan
- Relationships, Sex and Health Education Policy, and Curriculum Policy
- Preventing Extremism and Radicalisation Policy
- Restrictive Interventions Policy
- Premises Management Policy, Emergency and Business Continuity Plan, and Educational Visits Policy
- Data Protection Policy and Privacy Notices
- English as an Additional Language Policy, Admissions Policy and SEND Policy
- the arrangements for the designated teacher for looked-after and previously looked-after children (section 14)

APPENDIX 1: TYPES OF ABUSE

Abuse is a form of maltreatment of a child. Somebody may abuse or neglect a child by inflicting harm or by failing to act to prevent harm. Harm can include ill treatment that is not physical as well as the impact of witnessing ill treatment of others. This is particularly relevant to the impact on children of all forms of domestic abuse, including where they see, hear or experience its effects. Children may be abused in a family or in an institutional or community setting by those known to them or, more rarely, by others. Abuse can take place wholly online, or technology may be used to facilitate offline abuse. Children may be abused by an adult or adults or by another child or children. Children may also cause harm to other family members, often referred to as child to parent or carer abuse.

Physical abuse may involve hitting, shaking, throwing, poisoning, burning or scalding, drowning, suffocating or otherwise causing physical harm to a child. Physical harm may also be caused when a parent or carer fabricates the symptoms of, or deliberately induces, illness in a child.

Emotional abuse is the persistent emotional maltreatment of a child such as to cause severe and adverse effects on the child's emotional development. Some level of emotional abuse is involved in all types of maltreatment of a child, although it may occur alone. It may involve:

- conveying to a child that they are worthless or unloved, inadequate, or valued only insofar as they meet the needs of another person
- not giving the child opportunities to express their views, deliberately silencing them or 'making fun' of what they say or how they communicate
- age or developmentally inappropriate expectations being imposed on children. These may include interactions that are beyond a child's developmental capability, as well as overprotection and limitation of exploration and learning, or preventing the child from taking part in normal social interaction
- seeing or hearing the ill-treatment of another
- serious bullying (including cyberbullying), causing children frequently to feel frightened or in danger, or the exploitation or corruption of children
- verbal abuse such as criticism, belittling or name-calling

Sexual abuse involves forcing or enticing a child or young person to take part in sexual activities, not necessarily involving violence, whether or not the child is aware of what is happening. The activities may involve:

- physical contact, including assault by penetration (for example rape or penetration with an object) or non-penetrative acts such as masturbation, kissing, rubbing and touching outside of clothing
- non-contact activities, such as involving children in looking at, or in the production of, sexual images, watching sexual activities, encouraging children to behave in sexually inappropriate ways, or grooming a child in preparation for abuse

Sexual abuse can take place online, and technology can be used to facilitate offline abuse. It is not solely perpetrated by adult males. Women can also commit acts of sexual abuse, as can other children.

Neglect is the persistent failure to meet a child's basic physical and/or psychological needs, likely to result in the serious impairment of the child's health or development. Neglect may occur during pregnancy as a result of maternal substance abuse. Once a child is born, neglect may involve a parent or carer failing to:

- provide adequate food, clothing and shelter (including exclusion from home or abandonment)
- protect a child from physical and emotional harm or danger
- ensure adequate supervision (including the use of inadequate care-givers)
- ensure access to appropriate medical care or treatment

It may also include neglect of, or unresponsiveness to, a child's basic emotional needs.

Neglect can also happen in affluent families. Emotional neglect, pressure to succeed, a lack of supervision, material indulgence and exposure to substance use or risky behaviour can be missed when a child appears well cared for, or when it is assumed that wealth means safety. Staff stay professionally curious about every pupil, for example a pupil with poor self-worth, independence beyond what is usual for their age, difficulty with empathy or friendships, or risk-taking and poor impulse control, and they share any concern with the DSL.

APPENDIX 2: SAFER RECRUITMENT AND DBS CHECKS

The steps below are based on part 3 of KCSIE 2026. Everyone involved in the recruitment and employment of staff to work with our pupils has received appropriate safer recruitment training. The Proprietor, the Chair of the School Governance Board, the Head Teacher and the person who maintains our Single Central Record complete safer recruitment training, and at least one trained person sits on every interview panel. Our recruitment materials make our commitment to safeguarding and promoting the welfare of children clear.

Advertising. When advertising roles, we make clear our commitment to safeguarding and promoting the welfare of children; that safeguarding checks will be undertaken; the safeguarding requirements and responsibilities of the role, including the extent of contact with children; and whether the role is exempt from the Rehabilitation of Offenders Act 1974 and the Exceptions Order 1975 (as amended). If the role is exempt, certain spent convictions and cautions are 'protected', so they do not need to be disclosed, and if they are disclosed we cannot take them into account.

Application forms. We use application forms rather than CVs, including for internal appointments. They include a statement that it is an offence to apply for the role if the applicant is barred from regulated activity relevant to children (where the role involves it), and a copy of, or link to, this policy and our policy on the employment of ex-offenders.

Shortlisting. Shortlisting involves at least 2 people, considers any inconsistencies and gaps in employment and the reasons given, and explores all potential concerns. We ask shortlisted candidates to complete a self-declaration (Appendix 5) of their criminal record or any information that would make them unsuitable to work with children, so they can share relevant information and discuss it at interview. It asks whether they have a criminal history, are on the barred list, are prohibited from teaching, have committed offences in any country, are known to the police or children's social care, have been disqualified from providing childcare, or have any relevant overseas information, and they sign to confirm it is true. We will also consider an online search of shortlisted candidates to identify publicly available incidents or issues, and tell them we may do so.

References and employment history. We obtain references before interview wherever possible, and explore any concerns with referees and take them up with the candidate at interview. We do not accept open references (for example 'to whom it may concern'), do not rely on applicants to obtain their own reference, and liaise directly with referees and verify information with them. At least one reference is from the current or most recent employer and completed by a senior person; where the referee is school-based, we ask the Head Teacher or principal to confirm it is accurate on disciplinary matters. If the candidate is not currently employed, we verify their most recent relevant period of employment, and if they are not currently working with children we obtain a reference from the employer for the last time they did. We make sure electronic references come from a legitimate source, contact referees to clarify vague or insufficient information, establish the reason the applicant left their current or most recent post, compare the application form with the reference, and resolve any concern before an appointment is confirmed.

Interview and selection. We probe gaps in employment, or frequent changes of employer or location, and ask candidates to explain them; explore any potential areas of concern to decide suitability to work with children; and record all information considered and decisions made.

Pre-appointment vetting checks (new staff). We record all checks on our Single Central Record (SCR), maintained by the Head Teacher, with copies held on personnel files where appropriate. All offers of appointment are conditional until satisfactory completion of the checks. When appointing new staff we will:

- verify their identity
- obtain, via the applicant, an enhanced DBS certificate including barred list information for those engaging in regulated activity, before or as soon as practicable after appointment, including when using the DBS update service. We do not keep a copy of the certificate for longer than 6 months, but we may keep a record that vetting took place, the result and the recruitment decision
- obtain a separate barred list check for newly appointed staff or volunteers who start work in regulated activity before the DBS certificate is available, or whose previous post in a school or college that brought them into regular contact with children ended not more than 3 months before their appointment
- verify their mental and physical fitness to carry out their work responsibilities
- verify their right to work in the UK, keeping a copy for the duration of employment and for 2 years afterwards
- verify their professional qualifications, as appropriate
- for teachers, check they are not subject to a prohibition order, using the Teaching Regulation Agency's Teacher Services system
- for management positions (most likely headteachers, principals and deputy or assistant headteachers), check they are not subject to a prohibition from management (section 128) direction
- carry out further checks on candidates who have lived or worked outside the UK, including an overseas criminal records check where available and, for teaching positions, a letter from the professional regulating authority in the country where they worked confirming no sanctions or restrictions

Because our pupils are aged 11 to 16 and we have no EYFS provision or wraparound childcare for under 8s, the additional disqualification checks under the Childcare Act 2006 and the 2018 Childcare Disqualification Regulations do not apply and are not carried out.

Regulated activity is work that a barred person must not do. It applies to both paid staff and volunteers, except where stated.

Activity	Frequency
Teaching, training, instructing, caring for or supervising children; providing advice or guidance on physical, emotional or educational wellbeing; (for paid workers only) any other paid work in school that gives an opportunity for contact with children	Frequently (once a week or more), or on more than 3 days in a 30-day period, or once at any time between 2am and 6am with the opportunity for face-to-face contact with children

Activity	Frequency
Driving a vehicle only for children and their carers or supervisors	Frequently (once a week or more), or on more than 3 days in a 30-day period
Providing intimate or personal care (assisting with toileting, washing, bathing and dressing due to age, illness or disability; assisting with eating and drinking due to illness or disability; providing health care, physical or mental)	Any time, even if only once
Moderating a public electronic interactive communication service (for example the school's social media platforms) likely to be used wholly or mainly by children	Any time

Following the Crime and Policing Act 2026, the 'supervision exemption' has been removed, so anyone volunteering in a role that involves teaching, training, instructing, caring for or supervising children on more than 3 days in a 30-day period, or overnight, is in regulated activity and needs an enhanced DBS check with a children's barred list check, even where a member of staff is present. Intimate or personal care is not a routine part of any role here, given our pupils' ages, but where it arises (for example in a pupil's health care plan) the checks apply in full.

Existing staff and volunteers. We carry out all the relevant checks as if the person were newly appointed where there are concerns about their suitability to work with children, where they move from a post that is not regulated activity to one that is, or where there has been a break in service of 12 weeks or more. We refer to the DBS anyone who has harmed, or poses a risk of harm to, a child or vulnerable adult where we believe they have engaged in relevant conduct, have received a caution or conviction for a relevant offence, or the 'harm test' is satisfied, and they have been removed from regulated activity (paid or unpaid) or would have been had they not left. This duty applies equally to paid staff and volunteers.

Agency and third-party staff. We obtain written notification from any agency or third-party organisation that it has carried out the safer recruitment checks we would otherwise perform, and we check that the person presenting for work is the same person on whom the checks were made.

Contractors. We make sure any contractor, or employee of a contractor, has the appropriate DBS check: enhanced with barred list information for those in regulated activity,

and enhanced without barred list information for those not in regulated activity but with an opportunity for regular contact with children. We obtain the check for self-employed contractors, or ask to see their certificate and confirm it is at the level we need. We do not keep copies for longer than 6 months. Contractors without checks do not work unsupervised or engage in regulated activity under any circumstances, and we check the identity of all contractors and their staff on arrival.

Trainee and student teachers. Where a trainee is salaried by us, we make sure all necessary checks are carried out. Where a trainee is fee-funded, we obtain written confirmation from the training provider that the necessary checks have been carried out and that the trainee has been judged suitable to work with children.

Volunteers. We do not currently use volunteers. If we ever do, we will never leave an unchecked volunteer unsupervised or allow them to work in regulated activity; we will obtain an enhanced DBS check with children's barred list information for all volunteers new to regulated activity, and, for any existing volunteer who is engaging in regulated activity from 1 September 2026, an enhanced DBS check with children's barred list information, or a standalone barred list check where we want the volunteer to start before the certificate is available or where we recently obtained an enhanced check without barred list information and there has been no break in service since; and for volunteers not in regulated activity we will carry out and record a risk assessment when deciding whether to seek an enhanced check without barred list information.

Members of the School Governance Board and the Proprietor. All members will have an enhanced DBS check without barred list information, or with barred list information if working in regulated activity. The Chair's DBS check is countersigned by the Secretary of State. As an independent school, all proprietors and members of the Board will also have a section 128 check, an identity check, a right to work in the UK check, and any other checks considered necessary where they have lived or worked outside the UK.

Alternative provision. Where we place a pupil with an alternative provision provider, we obtain written confirmation that the provider has carried out the safeguarding checks on the people working there that we would otherwise perform.

Work experience, music tuition and host families. When we organise work experience, we make sure policies and procedures protect children from harm, and consider whether barred list checks are needed for adults supervising a pupil under 16, depending on the nature and frequency of supervision and whether the work is regulated activity. A visiting music or other one-to-one tutor has the same checks as any other adult working with our pupils, tuition takes place where possible in a room visible from a corridor or with the door open, a risk assessment is completed, parents and carers are told what contact is involved, and the tutor does not travel alone with a pupil or contact them directly on a mobile phone or personal social media. It would not be appropriate for our pupils to stay with host families, for example on an exchange. If that ever changed, we would request enhanced DBS checks with barred list information on the adults, or, overseas, work with partner organisations to secure equivalent assurance.

Induction and staff support. All staff must be aware of the systems that support safeguarding, and these are explained at induction, including this policy, part 1 of KCSIE, the Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy, the response to children who go missing from education, and the identity and role of the DSL and deputies. See section 19.5 for staff supervision.

APPENDIX 3: ALLEGATIONS AGAINST STAFF

Section 1: allegations that may meet the harm threshold. This section is based on part 4 of KCSIE 2026 and applies to all cases in which it is alleged that a current member of staff, including a supply teacher, trainee teacher, volunteer or contractor, has:

- behaved in a way that has harmed a child, or may have harmed a child, and/or
- possibly committed a criminal offence against or related to a child, and/or
- behaved towards a child or children in a way that indicates they may pose a risk of harm to children, and/or
- behaved or may have behaved in a way that indicates they may not be suitable to work with children. This includes behaviour inside and outside school

If we are in any doubt whether a concern meets the harm threshold, we consult the LADO. We deal with any allegation quickly, fairly and consistently, so that it provides effective child protection while also supporting the person who is the subject of the allegation. A 'case manager' leads any investigation. This is the Head Teacher, or the Chair of the School Governance Board where the Head Teacher is the subject of the allegation. Where the allegation is about the Proprietor, it goes directly to the LADO team, who decide what happens next. The case manager is identified at the earliest opportunity, and procedures are applied with common sense and judgement. If we receive an allegation of an incident that happened while an individual or organisation was using our premises to run activities for children, we follow our safeguarding procedures and inform the LADO.

Suspension. Suspension of the accused is not the default position, and will only be considered where there is reason to suspect that a child or other children are at risk of harm, or the case is so serious that there might be grounds for dismissal. We will only suspend if we have considered all other options and there is no reasonable alternative. Based on an assessment of risk, we consider alternatives such as providing an assistant when the person has contact with children, redeploying the individual so they have no unsupervised access to children or no contact with the child concerned, moving the child or children so that they do not come into contact with the individual (making clear it is not a punishment and that parents and carers have been consulted), or temporarily redeploying the person to another role or location. If in doubt, the case manager seeks the views of our HR adviser and the LADO, and of the police and children's social care where they have been involved.

Outcomes of allegation investigations. Substantiated: there is sufficient evidence to prove the allegation. Malicious: there is sufficient evidence to disprove the allegation and there has been a deliberate act to deceive or to cause harm to the subject of the allegation. False: there is sufficient evidence to disprove the allegation. Unsubstantiated: there is insufficient evidence to either prove or disprove the allegation (this does not imply guilt or innocence). Unfounded: there is no evidence or proper basis that supports the allegation.

Procedure. In the event of an allegation that meets the criteria above, the case manager will:

- conduct basic enquiries in line with local procedures to establish the facts and help decide whether there is any foundation to the allegation
- discuss the allegation with the LADO, to consider its nature, content and context and agree a course of action, including whether further enquiries are needed and whether the police and/or children's social care should be involved. The case manager may

involve the police first if the accused is an immediate risk to children or there is evidence of a possible criminal offence, and will tell the LADO as soon as practicable afterwards

- inform the accused of the concerns or allegations and the likely course of action as soon as possible after speaking to the LADO (and the police or children's social care where necessary), sharing only what has been agreed with those agencies
- where appropriate, carefully consider whether suspension is justified or whether alternative arrangements can be made, seeking advice from the LADO, police and/or children's social care as appropriate
- where the case manager is concerned about the welfare of other children in the community or the individual's family, discuss these concerns with the DSL and risk-assess the situation. If necessary, the DSL may make a referral to children's social care
- if immediate suspension is considered necessary, agree and record the rationale with the LADO, including the alternatives considered and why they were rejected. Written confirmation of the suspension is given to the individual within 1 working day, with a named contact at the school and their details
- if it is decided that no further action is to be taken, record the decision and the justification and agree with the LADO what information should be put in writing to the individual and by whom, and what action should follow for the individual and for those who made the allegation
- if further action is needed, take the steps agreed with the LADO to start the appropriate action in school and/or liaise with the police and/or children's social care
- provide effective support for the individual facing the allegation, including appointing a named representative to keep them informed of progress and considering what other support is appropriate, such as advice from a trade union representative or a colleague, and access to welfare counselling or medical advice
- inform the parents or carers of the child or children involved about the allegation as soon as possible if they do not already know (after agreement with children's social care and/or the police if applicable), tell them about the requirement to maintain confidentiality about any allegation against a teacher while investigations are ongoing, and advise any parent or carer who wishes to remove the restriction to seek legal advice. We keep them informed of the progress of the case, in relation to their child only
- make a referral to the DBS where it is thought that the individual has engaged in conduct that harmed or is likely to harm a child, or otherwise poses a risk of harm to a child

Support for staff. We support any member of staff facing an allegation. Their named representative keeps them informed of progress, they can ask for advice from a trade union representative or a colleague, and we help them get welfare counselling or medical advice. To ask for support in confidence, contact the Proprietor or the Chair of the School Governance Board directly.

If we are told that the Secretary of State has made an interim prohibition order about an individual, we will immediately suspend that individual from teaching, pending the Teaching Regulation Agency's investigation. Where the police are involved, we will ask them at the

start of the investigation, where possible, to obtain consent from the individuals involved to share their statements and evidence for use in our disciplinary process.

Supply teachers, trainee teachers and all contracted staff. If there is a concern or allegation about someone not directly employed by us, such as a supply teacher, trainee teacher or contracted staff member provided by an agency, we share safeguarding responsibilities with the employer. In addition to the usual procedures, we will not decide to stop using an individual because of safeguarding concerns without finding out the facts and liaising with the LADO to decide a suitable outcome; we will discuss with the agency whether it is appropriate to suspend or redeploy the individual while we investigate; we will involve the agency fully, but we take the lead in collecting the information and providing it to the LADO; and we will address information sharing so that any previous concerns or allegations known to the agency are taken into account. We tell agencies about our process for managing allegations and invite their HR manager or equivalent to meetings as appropriate. Teacher training providers follow the same procedures.

Timescales. We deal with all allegations as quickly and effectively as possible and try to meet these timescales where reasonably practicable: cases where it is clear immediately that the allegation is unsubstantiated or malicious are resolved within 1 week; if the allegation does not need formal disciplinary action, appropriate action is taken within 3 working days; and if a disciplinary hearing is needed and can be held without further investigation, it is held within 15 working days. These are objectives, and where they are not met we take the required action as soon as possible after.

Specific actions. After a criminal investigation or prosecution, the case manager discusses with the LADO whether any further action, including disciplinary action, is appropriate, taking into account information from the police and children's social care. If an allegation is substantiated and the individual is dismissed, or we stop using their services, or they resign or otherwise stop providing their services, we make a referral to the DBS for consideration of barring, and, for teaching staff, consider referring the matter to the Teaching Regulation Agency. If a suspended individual is to return to work, the case manager considers how best to facilitate this and how to manage their contact with the child or children who made the allegation, if still on roll. If an allegation is unsubstantiated, unfounded, false or malicious, the LADO and case manager consider the next steps, which may include a referral to children's social care if the child or person who made the allegation needs help or it may have been a cry for help, and, if it was deliberately invented or malicious, whether any disciplinary action is appropriate against the person who made it.

Confidentiality and information sharing. We make every effort to maintain confidentiality and guard against unwanted publicity while an allegation is being investigated or considered. The case manager takes advice from the LADO, police and children's social care to agree who needs to know about the allegation and what can be shared, how to manage speculation, leaks and gossip (including making the parents or carers of the children involved aware of their confidentiality obligations), what, if anything, can reasonably be given to the wider community to reduce speculation, and how to manage press interest if and when it arises.

Record-keeping. The case manager keeps clear records of any case that meets these criteria and stores them on the individual's confidential personnel file for the duration of the case. Records of an allegation found after investigation to be malicious or false are deleted from the personnel file, unless the individual agrees they can stay. For all other allegations, the file holds a clear and comprehensive summary of the allegation, details of how it was

followed up and resolved, notes of any action taken, decisions reached and the outcome, and a declaration on whether the information will be referred to in any future reference. We give the individual a copy, in agreement with children's social care or the police as appropriate. We keep all records at least until the individual reaches normal pension age, or for 10 years from the date of the allegation if that is longer.

References. When providing employer references, we do not refer to any allegation that has been found to be false, unfounded, unsubstantiated or malicious, or to repeated allegations that were all found to be so. We include substantiated allegations, provided the information is factual and does not include opinions.

Learning lessons. After any case where the allegation is substantiated, the case manager reviews the circumstances with the LADO to decide whether we can improve our procedures or practice to help prevent similar events, including issues arising from any decision to suspend, the length of the suspension, whether it was justified, and, if the person is reinstated, how a similar investigation could be done without suspension. For all other cases, the case manager considers the facts and decides whether any improvement can be made.

Non-recent allegations. Abuse can be reported no matter how long ago it happened. We report any non-recent allegation made by a child to the LADO in line with Birmingham's procedures. Where an adult tells us they were abused as a child, we advise them to report it to the police.

Section 2: concerns that do not meet the harm threshold (low-level concerns). This section is based on part 4 of KCSIE and applies to all concerns, including allegations, about members of staff, including supply teachers, trainee teachers, volunteers and contractors, that do not meet the harm threshold. Concerns may arise through suspicion, a complaint, a safeguarding concern or allegation from another member of staff, a disclosure by a child, parent or other adult within or outside school, or pre-employment vetting checks. We respond to concerns in a timely manner to safeguard children.

A **low-level concern** is any concern, no matter how small, that an adult working in or on behalf of the school may have acted in a way that is inconsistent with the Staff Code of Conduct, including inappropriate conduct outside work, and does not meet the allegations threshold or is otherwise not serious enough to consider a referral to the LADO. Examples include being overly friendly with children, having favourites, taking photographs of children on a personal mobile phone, engaging with a child one-to-one in a secluded area or behind a closed door, and humiliating pupils.

Sharing low-level concerns. We want a culture of openness, trust and transparency so that staff confidentially share low-level concerns and they can be addressed appropriately. Staff must share any low-level concern with the Head Teacher (our nominated person). If it concerns the Head Teacher, it goes to the Chair of the School Governance Board. If a person other than the Head Teacher ever receives a low-level concern, they will share it with the Head Teacher in a timely manner according to its nature. We create this culture by making sure staff are clear about appropriate behaviour and confident in telling expected behaviour from concerning, problematic or inappropriate behaviour in themselves and others; empowering staff to share low-level concerns as set out in section 7.7 and to self-refer; addressing unprofessional behaviour and supporting the person to correct it early; responding sensitively and proportionately when concerns are raised; and using concerns to spot any weakness in our safeguarding system.

Responding to low-level concerns. If a concern is raised by a third party, the Head Teacher collects evidence where necessary by speaking directly to the person who raised it (unless it was anonymous) and to the individual involved and any witnesses. The Head Teacher uses the information to categorise the behaviour and decide further action, in line with the Staff Code of Conduct. The Head Teacher is the ultimate decision-maker for all low-level concerns and may choose to consult the Proprietor or deputy DSLs and take a more collaborative decision.

Record-keeping. All low-level concerns are recorded in writing, with the context in which the concern arose, any action taken and the reasons for decisions. Records are kept confidential and held securely, and comply with the Data Protection Act 2018, the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025 and the UK GDPR. They are reviewed so that patterns of concerning, problematic or inappropriate behaviour can be identified. Where a pattern is found, we decide on a course of action, through our disciplinary procedures or, where the pattern moves from a concern to meeting the harm threshold, by referral to the LADO. Records are kept at least until the individual leaves employment at the school. Where a low-level concern relates to a supply teacher or contractor, we tell their employer so that any pattern can be identified.

References. We do not include low-level concerns in references unless the concern (or group of concerns) has met the threshold for referral to the LADO and is found to be substantiated, or relates to issues that would ordinarily be included in a reference, such as misconduct or poor performance.

APPENDIX 4: SPECIFIC SAFEGUARDING ISSUES

This appendix is based mostly on part 1 of KCSIE 2026 and on locally agreed procedures put in place by the 3 safeguarding partners.

Assessing adult-involved nude and semi-nude sharing incidents. All adult-involved nude and semi-nude image sharing incidents are child sexual abuse offences and must immediately be referred to the police and/or children's social care. Adult-involved incidents can present as child-on-child sharing, so it may be difficult to assess adult involvement at first. There are two common types.

Sexually motivated incidents. An adult offender obtains nudes and semi-nudes directly from a child using online platforms. The offender may present as themselves or use a false identity, sometimes posing as a child to build trust, often grooms the child on social media, in chatrooms or on gaming platforms, and may move the conversation to a private or end-to-end encrypted (E2EE) messaging app where a request for a nude is made. They may share pornography or child sexual abuse material (including AI-generated material) to encourage the child. Once a child shares an image, the offender may blackmail them into sending more by threatening to release them. Potential signs include a child being contacted by an unknown account that appears to be another child, quickly engaged in sexually explicit communication, moved from a public to a private or E2EE platform, coerced into sexual acts including creating nudes, offered something of value such as money or gaming credits, or threatened or blackmailed into further sexual activity, including with a digitally manipulated image.

Financially motivated incidents. Financially motivated sexual extortion ('sextortion') is where an adult offender, usually working in an organised crime group overseas, threatens to release nudes or semi-nudes of a child unless they pay money or do something else to benefit them. Offenders often use a false identity, or a hacked account of another young person, to make contact. They may groom or coerce the child into sending images, use images stolen by hacking, or use digitally manipulated or AI-generated images, and may demand payment or the use of the child's bank account for money laundering. Signs include contact from an unknown or hacked account, quickly engaged in sexually explicit communication, a move from a public to a private or E2EE platform, pressure to take nudes, being told they have been hacked, and being blackmailed to send money or bank details.

Children who are absent from education. A child being absent from education for prolonged periods and/or on repeat occasions can be a warning sign of a range of safeguarding issues, including abuse or neglect, sexual abuse or exploitation, child criminal exploitation, mental health problems, substance abuse, radicalisation, FGM or forced marriage. Children who are particularly at risk of becoming missing from education include those at risk of harm or neglect, at risk of forced marriage or FGM, from Gypsy, Roma or Traveller families, from service families, who go missing or run away from home or care, who are supervised by the youth justice system, who cease to attend a school, or who come from new migrant families. We follow our unauthorised absence procedures and our Children Missing Education and Missing Pupils Policy so that we identify the risk of abuse, exploitation and neglect and prevent the risk of going missing in future. This includes informing the placing local authority if a child leaves without a new school being named, and sharing information with the local authority, where required, when removing a child's name from the admission register at non-standard transition points. We hold two or more emergency contact numbers for each pupil and adapt our attendance monitoring for each

pupil's safety. If a staff member suspects a child is suffering harm or neglect, we follow local child protection procedures, including making reasonable enquiries, and make an immediate referral to children's social care and the police if the child is suffering or likely to suffer harm, or in immediate danger.

Child criminal exploitation (CCE). CCE is a form of abuse where an individual or group takes advantage of an imbalance of power to coerce, control, manipulate or deceive a child into criminal activity. It may involve an exchange for something the victim needs or wants, and/or the financial or other advantage of the perpetrator or facilitator, and/or violence or the threat of violence. It can be carried out by males or females, and children or adults, as a one-off or a series of incidents, from opportunistic to complex organised abuse, by organised networks or gangs, and the victim may identify as part of the group. The victim can be exploited even when the activity appears consensual. It does not always involve physical contact and can happen online. Examples include forced work in cannabis factories, moving drugs or money across the country (county lines), shoplifting, pickpocketing and threatening other young people. It can include children who have been moved for the purpose of exploitation, which may be modern slavery. Indicators include a child appearing with unexplained gifts or new possessions, associating with other young people involved in exploitation, changes in emotional wellbeing, misusing drugs and alcohol, going missing for periods of time or regularly coming home late, regularly missing school, and not taking part in education. If staff suspect CCE, they talk to the DSL, who triggers local safeguarding procedures, including a referral to CASS and the police if appropriate, and uses the national referral mechanism where there are signs of modern slavery. Recruitment increasingly happens through social media and over short distances, so a pupil may be drawn into criminal activity within the same city and not only through 'county lines' travel.

Child sexual exploitation (CSE). CSE is a form of child sexual abuse where an individual or group takes advantage of an imbalance of power to coerce, manipulate or deceive a child into sexual activity. It may involve an exchange for something the victim needs or wants and/or the financial advantage or increased status of the perpetrator or facilitator, and may or may not be accompanied by violence or threats of violence. It can be carried out by males or females, and children or adults, as a one-off or a series of incidents. It can be committed or facilitated by an organised network or gang, and victims are not always recognised and can be criminalised for actions they take while under coercion. The victim can be exploited even when the activity appears consensual. Children who are sexually exploited may not understand that they are being abused, may trust their abuser, and may be tricked into believing they are in a loving, consensual relationship. CSE includes physical contact and non-contact activity, and can happen online, for example young people persuaded or forced to share sexually explicit images, have sexual conversations by text or take part in sexual activities using a webcam. It can include children moved for the purpose of exploitation, which may be modern slavery. In addition to the CCE indicators, indicators of CSE include having an older boyfriend or girlfriend, and suffering from sexually transmitted infections or becoming pregnant. If staff suspect CSE, they talk to the DSL, who triggers local safeguarding procedures, including referral to CASS and the police if appropriate.

Child-on-child abuse (including harassment and violence). Child-on-child abuse is when children abuse other children. It can take place inside and outside school, face-to-face and online, and can occur simultaneously between the two. It is a safeguarding issue for both victim and alleged perpetrator, it is preventable, and it may involve serious physical harm or threats involving weapons. We have a zero-tolerance approach to sexual violence and

sexual harassment, and we recognise that even if there are no reports it does not mean it is not happening. It is most likely to include, but may not be limited to:

- bullying (including cyberbullying, prejudice-based and discriminatory bullying)
- discriminatory behaviour, including racism, faith-targeted abuse and other prejudice-based incidents
- abuse in intimate personal relationships between children (sometimes known as 'teenage relationship abuse')
- physical abuse such as hitting, kicking, shaking, biting, hair pulling or otherwise causing physical harm (which may include an online element that facilitates, threatens or encourages physical abuse)
- physical assault and harm, or the threat of harm with a weapon
- harmful sexual behaviour (an umbrella term which applies to behaviour online, face-to-face or both), sexual violence and sexual harassment, which may include misogyny or misandry
- causing someone to engage in sexual activity without consent, such as forcing someone to strip, touch themselves sexually, or engage in sexual activity with a third party
- consensual and non-consensual making or sharing of nudes and semi-nudes, including those generated using AI
- upskirting, which is a criminal offence and typically involves taking a picture under a person's clothing without their permission, with the intention of viewing their genitals or buttocks to obtain sexual gratification, or to cause the victim humiliation, distress or alarm
- initiation or hazing-type violence and rituals, which could include activities involving harassment, abuse or humiliation used as a way of initiating a person into a group and which may include an online element

Where children abuse their peers online, this can take the form of abusive, harassing and misogynistic messages, the non-consensual sharing of nude or semi-nude images (especially in chat groups), and the sharing of abusive images and pornography with those who do not want to receive it. Staff who have concerns about child-on-child abuse, or to whom a child makes a report, follow section 7 of this policy, in particular sections 7.8 and 7.9. When we consider harmful sexual behaviour between children, we consider their ages and stages of development, recognise that children who display harmful sexual behaviour have often experienced their own abuse and trauma, and offer them appropriate support. We use local guidance on children who abuse others, including the Birmingham School Safety Plan for children who pose a risk to other children.

Domestic abuse. Children can witness and be adversely affected by domestic abuse and/or violence at home between family members. A child may blame themselves for the abuse or may have had to leave the family home as a result. Types of domestic abuse include intimate partner violence, abuse by family members, teenage relationship abuse (abuse in intimate personal relationships between children, including physical, sexual and emotional abuse, and stalking), and child or adolescent to parent violence and abuse. It can be physical, sexual, financial, psychological or emotional. It can include ill treatment that is not physical, and witnessing the ill treatment of others. Anyone can be a victim of domestic abuse, regardless of gender, age, ethnicity, socioeconomic status, sexuality or background,

and it can happen inside or outside the home. Children who witness it are also victims. Older children may experience, or be perpetrators of, domestic abuse in their own relationships, which can include sexual harassment. Exposure can have a serious, long-lasting emotional and psychological impact and affect health, wellbeing, development and ability to learn. Under Operation Encompass, the police must notify us of a domestic abuse incident where a child is involved, has witnessed or been present, lives at or is linked to the address, or where a Child Concern Notification has been issued, regardless of whether the child was there at the time. The police inform the key adult in school (our DSL) before the child arrives the next day, and the notification should reflect the voice of the child. The DSL provides support according to the child's needs and updates their records.

Homelessness. Being homeless or at risk of becoming homeless presents a real risk to a child's welfare. The DSL and deputies are aware of the contact details and referral routes in the local housing authority so they can raise and progress concerns at the earliest opportunity, in line with local procedures. Where a child has been harmed or is at risk of harm, the DSL also makes a referral to children's social care. Where children live independently from their parents or carers (for example, if they have been excluded from the family home), we work with children's social care to support them.

So-called 'honour-based' abuse (HBA). HBA covers incidents or crimes committed to protect or defend the honour of the family and/or community, including FGM, forced marriage and practices such as breast ironing. It often involves a wider network of family or community pressure and can involve multiple perpetrators. All forms of HBA are abuse and are handled and escalated as such. All staff are alert to the possibility of a child being at risk of HBA or having already suffered it. If staff have a concern, they speak to the DSL, who activates local safeguarding procedures.

FGM. The DSL makes sure staff have access to appropriate training to be alert to children affected by or at risk of FGM. Section 7.3 sets out what to do. Indicators that FGM may already have happened include a pupil confiding in a professional that it has; a mother or family member disclosing it; a family or pupil already known to social services for other safeguarding issues; and a girl having difficulty walking, sitting or standing or looking uncomfortable; finding it hard to sit still for long periods; spending longer than normal in the bathroom or toilet due to difficulties urinating; having frequent urinary, menstrual or stomach problems; avoiding physical exercise or missing PE; being repeatedly absent from school or absent for a prolonged period; showing increased emotional and psychological needs, such as withdrawal, depression or a significant change in behaviour; being reluctant to undergo medical examinations; asking for help without being explicit about the problem; or talking about pain or discomfort between her legs. Potential signs that a pupil may be at risk include a family history of practising FGM (the biggest risk factor); FGM being known to be practised in the girl's community or country of origin; a parent or family member expressing concern that FGM may be carried out; a family not engaging with professionals or already known to social care; and a girl who has a mother, older sibling or cousin who has undergone FGM, has limited integration within UK society, confides that she is to have a 'special procedure' or attend a special occasion to 'become a woman', talks about a long holiday to her country of origin or another country where the practice is prevalent (or parents or carers say a relative will take her out of the country for a prolonged period), asks a teacher or another adult for help because she is aware or suspects she is at immediate risk, talks about FGM in conversation, is unexpectedly absent from school, or has sections missing from her 'red book' (child health record) or attends a travel clinic or equivalent for vaccinations or anti-malarial medication. These indicators are not exhaustive.

Forced marriage. Forcing a person into marriage is a crime. A forced marriage is one entered into without the full and free consent of one or both parties and where violence, threats or any other form of coercion is used to make a person enter into a marriage. Threats can be physical or emotional and psychological. Since February 2023 it is also illegal to cause a child under 18 to marry, even if violence, threats or coercion are not involved. Staff are trained on forced marriage and its signs. We are aware of the 'one chance' rule: we may only have one chance to speak to a potential victim and one chance to save them. If a member of staff suspects a pupil is being forced into marriage, they speak to the pupil about their concerns in a secure and private place and report it to the DSL. The DSL speaks to the pupil in a secure and private place, activates local safeguarding procedures and refers the case to CASS and the LADO where an adult is involved, seeks advice from the Forced Marriage Unit on 020 7008 0151 (fmu@fcdo.gov.uk), and refers the pupil to appropriate support in school.

Preventing radicalisation. Radicalisation is the process of a person legitimising support for, or use of, terrorist violence. Extremism is the vocal or active opposition to fundamental British values, including democracy, the rule of law, individual liberty, and mutual respect and tolerance of those with different faiths and beliefs. Terrorism is an action that endangers or causes serious violence to a person or people, causes serious damage to property, or seriously interferes with or disrupts an electronic system, designed to influence the government or intimidate the public and made for the purpose of advancing a political, religious or ideological cause. We have a duty to prevent children from becoming involved with or supporting terrorism. The DSL, who is our Prevent lead, has in-depth Prevent awareness training, including on extremist and terrorist ideologies, and makes sure staff have access to appropriate training. We assess the risk of children in our school being drawn into terrorism, based on an understanding of the local risk in collaboration with our safeguarding partners and West Midlands Police, we make sure suitable internet filtering is in place, and we equip pupils to stay safe online. There is no single way of identifying who is susceptible, and radicalisation can occur quickly or over a long period. Signs can include refusing to engage with, or becoming abusive to, peers who are different; becoming susceptible to conspiracy theories and feelings of persecution; changes in friendship groups and appearance; rejecting activities they used to enjoy; converting to a new religion; isolating themselves from family and friends; talking as if from a scripted speech; an unwillingness or inability to discuss their views; a sudden disrespectful attitude towards others; increased anger; increased secretiveness, especially around internet use; expressing sympathy for extremist ideologies and groups or justifying their actions; accessing extremist material online; possessing extremist literature; and being in contact with extremist recruiters or joining or seeking to join extremist organisations. Children at risk may have low self-esteem, or be victims of bullying or discrimination, and these signs can also be part of normal teenage behaviour, so staff should have confidence in their instincts and seek advice if something feels wrong. Staff follow section 7.5, and always take action if they are worried. Further measures are set out in our Preventing Extremism and Radicalisation Policy, our Curriculum and RSHE Policies, our Behaviour, Rewards and Sanctions Policy and our Online Safety Policy. We have a 'no platform' approach to speakers known to spread extremist views.

Harmful sexual behaviour (HSB), sexual violence and sexual harassment between children. We respond to all signs, reports and concerns of HSB, child-on-child sexual harassment and sexual violence, including those outside the school premises and/or online. Sexual violence refers to sexual offences under the Sexual Offences Act 2003:

- **Rape:** a person (A) commits rape if they intentionally penetrate the vagina, anus or mouth of another person (B) with their penis, B does not consent to the penetration, and A does not reasonably believe that B consents
- **Assault by penetration:** a person (A) commits an offence if they intentionally penetrate the vagina or anus of another person (B) with a part of their body or anything else, the penetration is sexual, B does not consent, and A does not reasonably believe that B consents
- **Sexual assault:** a person (A) commits an offence if they intentionally touch another person (B), the touching is sexual, B does not consent, and A does not reasonably believe that B consents. It covers a very wide range of behaviour, so a single act of kissing someone without consent, or touching someone's bottom, breasts or genitalia without consent, can still be sexual assault
- **Causing someone to engage in sexual activity without consent:** a person (A) commits an offence if they intentionally cause another person (B) to engage in an activity, the activity is sexual, B does not consent, and A does not reasonably believe that B consents. This could include forcing someone to strip, touch themselves sexually, or engage in sexual activity with a third party

Consent is about having the freedom and capacity to choose. Consent to sexual activity may be given to one sort of activity but not another, and can be withdrawn at any time during sexual activity and each time activity occurs. A child under 13 can never consent to any sexual activity, the age of consent is 16, and sexual intercourse without consent is rape. HSB can occur between 2 children of any age and sex, through a group of children sexually assaulting or sexually harassing a single child or group of children, and online and face to face (both physically and verbally). It exists on a continuum, may escalate into sexual harassment or sexual violence, is never acceptable, and sexual violence and sexual harassment may overlap. Victims will likely find the experience distressing, which will in all likelihood affect their educational attainment, and it is worse if the alleged perpetrator attends the same school. If a victim reports an incident, staff make sure they are reassured that they are being taken seriously and will be supported and kept safe. A victim is never given the impression that they are creating a problem by reporting any form of abuse, and is never made to feel ashamed. When supporting victims, staff reassure them that the law on child-on-child abuse is there to protect them, not criminalise them; regularly review decisions and actions and update policies with lessons learnt; look for potential patterns of concerning, problematic or inappropriate behaviour; consider whether wider cultural issues in the school enabled the behaviour and whether revised policies or extra staff training could reduce the risk; and stay alert to the challenges of detecting signs that a child has experienced sexual violence. Some groups are potentially more at risk. Evidence shows that girls, children with SEND, lesbian, gay and bisexual children and children questioning their gender are at greater risk. Staff challenge inappropriate behaviours; make clear that sexual violence and harassment is not acceptable, will never be tolerated and is not an inevitable part of growing up; challenge physical behaviours that are potentially criminal, such as grabbing bottoms, breasts and genitalia, pulling down trousers, flicking bras and lifting skirts, because dismissing or tolerating them risks normalising them; and recognise the intersection of misogyny or misandry with harmful sexual behaviour, because seemingly minor issues such as derogatory language can escalate. Staff follow section 7 of this policy, in particular 7.8 and 7.9.

Serious violence. Serious violence is a continuing safeguarding concern which may involve physical assault, carrying, threatening with or using weapons (often in the context of peer conflict or bullying), and criminal exploitation. Indicators that a child may be at risk from, or involved with, serious violent crime include increased absence from school, a change in friendships or relationships with older individuals or groups, a significant decline in performance, signs of self-harm or a significant change in wellbeing, signs of assault or unexplained injuries, and unexplained gifts or new possessions (which could mean the child has been approached by, or is involved with, individuals associated with criminal networks or gangs, and may be at risk of criminal exploitation). Risk factors include having been frequently absent, suspended, in alternative provision or permanently excluded; having been involved in offending such as theft or robbery; being male; having experienced child maltreatment; having used drugs or alcohol in early adolescence; and having previously been a victim or perpetrator of violence. Staff are alert to these indicators and risk factors, and to when children might be at highest risk around the school day, for example immediately after school. If a member of staff has a concern about a pupil being involved in, or at risk of, serious violence, including a child carrying or using a weapon, or expressing intent to do so, they report it to the DSL. The DSL assesses the risk to the pupil and others, considers wider information or concerns, takes appropriate action, puts a safety and support plan in place depending on the risk, and, where relevant, considers action to de-escalate peer conflict.

Misogyny, the 'manosphere' and online influencers. The 'manosphere' is a set of online communities, including incels, pick-up artists, men's rights activists and 'men going their own way', that promote hostility towards women and girls and harmful ideas about masculinity. Pupils may meet this content through social media, gaming and influencers, and may repeat slang or ideas without knowing where they come from. Staff challenge sexist and misogynistic language every time and treat it as child-on-child abuse where it is aimed at others. We teach pupils about gender stereotypes, consent, healthy relationships and the pressure on boys to hide their feelings. Persistent hateful views, a sense of grievance and a fascination with violence can also be signs of risk under our Preventing Extremism and Radicalisation Policy, and staff raise them with the DSL.

Private fostering. A private fostering arrangement is one made without the involvement of the local authority for the care of a child under 16 (under 18 if disabled) by someone other than a parent or immediate relative, which lasts or is expected to last 28 days or more. An immediate relative is a grandparent, brother, sister, uncle or aunt (full blood, half blood, or by marriage or civil partnership), or a step-parent. We have a mandatory duty to tell the local authority of a private fostering arrangement. We do this by contacting CASS (0121 303 1888) for a Birmingham child, or the child's home authority. The authority then checks that the child is being properly cared for.

Children and the court system, and children with family members in prison. Children may be involved in the court system as witnesses or victims, and we support them with information, and help from our DSL. A parent or family member's imprisonment can cause great difficulty for the child and family, and children are at risk of poor outcomes, including poverty, stigma, isolation and poor mental health. We stay alert to these pupils, support them through their key adult and the Lead for Mental Health, and work with agencies that support them.

Sport and off-site activities. Where we provide or facilitate sporting activities or visits, on or off site, we recognise the specific risks that can arise, including from coaches, instructors

and volunteers who may have unsupervised access to children. We carry out appropriate safer recruitment checks on people delivering sport, risk-assess activities, and staff stay alert to safeguarding issues in changing facilities, on trips and at away fixtures. See our Educational Visits Policy.

Premises and visitors. We comply with the regulations and safeguarding requirements for school premises, including the Education (Independent School Standards) Regulations 2014, and keep our premises safe and secure (see our Premises Management Policy). All visitors must verify their identity to the satisfaction of staff and leave their belongings, including mobile phones, in a safe place during their visit. If the visitor is unknown to us, we check their credentials and reason for visiting before allowing them to enter, and visitors should be ready to produce identification. Visitors sign in and wear a visitor's badge. Visitors who come for a professional purpose, such as educational psychologists, therapists and local authority officers, show photo ID and either show their DBS certificate, which is checked alongside their photo ID, or the organisation sending them provides prior written confirmation that the appropriate level of DBS check has been done. All other visitors, including visiting speakers, are accompanied by a member of staff at all times. We assess the age-appropriateness of what a visitor will deliver and whether checks are needed. We do not invite any speaker who is known to spread extremist views, and we carry out appropriate checks to make sure any individual or organisation using our facilities is not seeking to spread extremist views or radicalise pupils or staff. Visitors are shown our Safeguarding and Child Protection Visitor Information sheet, which names the DSL and deputies and explains what to do if they have a concern. Where another organisation hires or uses our premises to run activities for children, they must have their own appropriate safeguarding policies, and any allegation is reported to the LADO (section 5.3 and Appendix 3).

Non-collection of children. If a child is not collected at the end of the day, we will contact their parents or carers and their emergency contacts, and a member of staff the child knows will stay with them. If we cannot contact anyone and the child has not been collected after 30 mins, the DSL will contact CASS for advice, or the police if there is any concern for the child's safety. The incident is recorded on CPOMS, and repeated non-collection is treated as a possible indicator of neglect.

Missing pupils. Our procedures are designed to make sure a missing child is found and returned to effective supervision as soon as possible, and are set out in our Children Missing Education and Missing Pupils Policy. In summary, as soon as a pupil is found to be missing from school or from an activity, the member of staff tells the Head Teacher or DSL, staff search the premises and immediate surroundings, parents or carers are contacted, and if the pupil is not found **within 15 minutes, or at once where the pupil is high-risk**, the police are called on 999. The placing authority and social worker are told where relevant, and the incident is recorded on CPOMS and reviewed by the DSL.

APPENDIX 5: CANDIDATE SELF-DECLARATION FORM

This form is completed by shortlisted candidates for any post at the school, before interview, so that they can share relevant information and discuss it at interview. It is not a replacement for an enhanced DBS check. It does not ask about spent convictions and cautions that are protected (filtered) under the Rehabilitation of Offenders Act 1974 (Exceptions) Order 1975, as amended.

Candidate self-declaration and disclosure	
Name and position applied for	
Do you have any criminal convictions, cautions, reprimands or warnings that are not protected? If yes, give details	
Are you included on the children's barred list or the adults' barred list, or subject to any other bar or restriction on working with children?	
Are you prohibited from teaching, or subject to a prohibition from management (section 128) direction?	
Have you committed any criminal offence in any country, in line with the law that applies in England and Wales? If yes, give details	
Are you known to the police or to a local authority children's social care service in a way that might be relevant to working with children? If yes, give details	
Have you ever been disqualified from providing childcare, or been the subject of a disciplinary or safeguarding investigation that could affect your suitability to work with children? If yes, give details	
Have you lived or worked outside the UK in the last 5 years? Give details of any relevant overseas information	
Is there any other information that might affect your suitability to work with children?	
Declaration: I confirm that the information I have given is true and complete. Signature and date	

APPENDIX 6: SAFEGUARDING INBOX

This appendix sets out how the school's confidential safeguarding mailbox is set up and used. The mailbox is a way to pass on a concern in writing. It does not replace speaking to the DSL in person or by telephone, or recording the concern on CPOMS.

Address. The mailbox address is added to the important contacts table at the front of this policy and published on the school website once it is live. safeguarding@futuresmattereducation.co.uk.

Access. Only the DSL and both deputy DSLs (Benjamin Neasom, Carrie-Ann McGurk and Simone Welch) have access. Office staff do not have access unless the Head Teacher names a trained safeguarding administrator in writing. Two-step sign-in is switched on, and new messages are copied to all three people with access.

Emergencies. The mailbox is not monitored out of hours or in school holidays. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999. For an urgent concern during school hours, phone the school office on 0121 835 1360 and ask for the DSL. For an urgent concern outside school hours, contact the Children's Advice and Support Service on 0121 303 1888 (out of hours 0121 675 4806).

Automatic reply. Everyone who writes to the mailbox receives this reply: Thank you for contacting the Futures Matter safeguarding team. Your message has been received by the Designated Safeguarding Lead and deputies, and will be read on the next school day at the latest. This inbox is not monitored out of hours or in school holidays. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999. For urgent concerns about a child, contact the Children's Advice and Support Service on 0121 303 1888 (out of hours 0121 675 4806). To reach us during school hours, call 0121 835 1360.

Subject lines. Staff start the subject line with a prefix: URGENT (action needed today), CONCERN (a concern about a pupil), STAFF (a concern or low-level concern about an adult) or INFO (an update or query that needs no action). Use the pupil's initials only in the subject line and put the full name in the body of the message.

What to include. State the date and time, what was seen or heard in the person's own words, and what has already been done. Staff also record the concern on CPOMS: the email is only a way to flag it.

Concerns about the Head Teacher or Proprietor. The Head Teacher has access to this mailbox, so it must not be used to report a concern about the Head Teacher or the Proprietor. Follow Appendix 3 instead: a concern about the Head Teacher goes to the Chair of the School Governance Board, and a concern about the Proprietor goes directly to the LADO team. Chair of Governance Board Mark O'Donnell c.o.g@futuresmattereducation.co.uk

Checking and cover. The DSL or a deputy checks the mailbox at the start and end of every school day, and a named deputy covers any absence. The first person to read a message tells the other two, by reply or label, that it has been picked up.

Handling and records. Messages are never deleted and are never forwarded to personal accounts. Once a message has been actioned and logged on CPOMS, it is moved to a folder called Logged on CPOMS. Messages are kept in line with the records retention schedule (see section 18.0).

APPENDIX 7: OFFLINE CONCERN CARD FOR CLEANERS, CONTRACTORS AND OTHER ADULTS

Use this card if you work at the school but do not use CPOMS or email. Write what you saw or heard, in your own words and in pen. You can write in your own language, or ask someone to write it down for you. Give the completed card to the DSL or a deputy DSL in person. If none of them is on site, put it in the locked safeguarding concerns box in the school office and phone 0121 835 1360 to say a card has been left. If a child is in immediate danger, call 999.

Do not question a child, investigate, or promise to keep a secret. Do not use this card for a concern about the Head Teacher or the Proprietor (see section 7.11). Part 1 of Keeping Children Safe in Education is available in community languages: Keeping Children Safe in Education Part 1 Translations (LGFL).

Offline concern card (complete in pen)	**Write here**
Your name (you may leave this blank, but we can follow up better if we know who you are)	
Your job, and who employs you (for example school cleaner, agency worker, contractor)	
Date and time you saw or heard it, and today's date	
Where it happened	
Who it is about (a child's name or a description, or an adult)	
What you saw or heard, in the exact words used if you can	
Was anyone else there? Did anyone else see or hear it?	
What you did, and who you told	
Your signature and the date (optional)	
For DSL use only: date and time received, received by, CPOMS reference, action taken	

APPENDIX 8: OUT-OF-HOURS SAFEGUARDING PROTOCOL

This appendix applies when a safeguarding concern arises outside normal school hours: in the evening, at weekends, in school holidays, and when staff are off site on a trip or visit and cannot reach the DSL in the usual way. It sits alongside sections 7.1 to 7.11. The confidential safeguarding inbox is not monitored out of hours (Appendix 6), so it must never be relied on in an emergency.

1. Emergency contacts for the DSL and deputy DSLs. These numbers are for staff only, and must not be given to pupils, parents or visitors. Phone the first person on the list. If there is no answer, leave a short voicemail with your name and where you are, then phone the next person, and keep going down the list. Do not send details of a concern by text message or a personal messaging app.

Role	Name	Out-of-hours number
Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)	Benjamin Neasom, Head Teacher	07521 013 526 (Headteacher mobile)
Deputy DSL	Carrie-Ann McGurk, Proprietor	07743 449 149 (work mobile)
Deputy DSL	Simone Welch	N/A
If none of them can be reached	Use the emergency services or CASS	See section 2 and section 3

Simone Welch is not on call and cannot be reached out of hours. The list of placing authorities' out-of-hours numbers, and the other out-of-hours safeguarding contacts, are held in the safeguarding section of the SLT drive.

2. Local authority and other services out of hours. Use the number that matches the child. For a child from another local authority area, use that authority's out-of-hours children's services number from the DSL's list of placing authorities, and tell the DSL which route you used.

Service	Number and hours
Children's Advice and Support Service (CASS), Birmingham Children's Trust	0121 303 1888. Monday to Thursday 08:45 to 17:15, Friday 08:45 to 16:15.
Emergency out of hours, Birmingham (children and adults)	0121 675 4806
Local Authority Designated Officer (LADO), Birmingham Children's Trust	0121 675 1669, ladoteam@birminghamchildrenstrust.co.uk. Office hours only. Tell the Head Teacher at once, and report to the LADO team on the next working day.
Placing authority out-of-hours children's services (pupils from other areas)	See the DSL's list of placing authorities.
Adult Social Care Access Point (ACAP)	0121 303 1234, Monday to Friday 09:00 to 17:00. Out of hours 0121 675 4806.
Police	999 in an emergency, 101 otherwise.
NHS 111	111. Choose the mental health option for urgent mental health advice.

NSPCC helpline for professionals	0808 800 5000
Childline (for pupils)	0800 1111

Procedures, threshold guidance and training from the Birmingham Safeguarding Children Partnership are at Birmingham Safeguarding Children Partnership (BSCP).

3. When to contact the emergency services. Do not wait for the DSL if a child is in danger. Act first, then tell the DSL.

Situation	**Who to contact**
A child is in immediate danger or has been seriously harmed, a crime is in progress, someone is threatening serious violence, or a child has seriously injured themselves, taken an overdose or is at immediate risk of suicide	Call 999 (police and ambulance). Stay with the child. Then phone the DSL.
A child is missing and you believe they are at risk, or the missing pupils procedure says to call the police	Call 999, then the DSL (see Appendix 4, Missing pupils).
A child tells you about abuse or neglect, or you are worried they are not safe at home, but they are not in immediate danger	Phone the DSL. If you cannot reach anyone, phone CASS on 0121 303 1888 (out of hours 0121 675 4806). Do not send a child to an unsafe situation.
A child is not collected and no safe adult can be reached	Phone the DSL and the child's parents or carers. If none can be reached, phone CASS out of hours on 0121 675 4806 (see Appendix 4, Non-collection of children).
An urgent mental health or health need that is not an emergency	Phone NHS 111 (choose the mental health option), then the DSL. Call 999 if there is a risk to life.
A crime that is not an emergency, for example a pupil tells you about an offence	Phone 101 and tell the DSL.
A concern about extremism or terrorism	Call 999 if someone is in danger. Otherwise tell the DSL, or call the anti-terrorist hotline on 0800 789 321.
An allegation about an adult who works with children	Tell the Head Teacher. If it is about the Head Teacher, tell the Chair of the School Governance Board. If it is about the Proprietor, phone the LADO team (see section 7.7). Call 999 if a child is in immediate danger.

Online concerns. Indecent images of children are reported to the Internet Watch Foundation, and online sexual exploitation can be reported to CEOP. Advice for pupils, parents and staff on online safety is available from Kids Online World.

4. Recording a concern that arises out of hours.

Safety first. Get help for the child before you write anything down.

Tell the DSL. Phone the DSL, then the deputy DSLs in order. If you cannot reach any of them, use the emergency services or CASS as set out above, and tell the DSL as soon as

you can. A voicemail or text that says 'urgent safeguarding, please call me' is acceptable, but give no details.

Write it up the same day. Write what you saw or heard, in the child's own words, with the date, time and place, on a Notice of Concern form, or on CPOMS if you can log in securely from a school device. Stick to the facts. Do not hold the record on a personal phone, personal email or messaging app, and do not take photographs. If you have to make notes on a personal device in an emergency, send them to the DSL and delete them once the DSL confirms receipt.

The DSL records it on CPOMS. The DSL or a deputy DSL records every out-of-hours concern on CPOMS by the start of the next school day, or the first school day after a holiday. The record includes the times of any calls, who was spoken to, the advice given, and what was decided and why.

Follow up. The DSL reviews the concern at the start of the next school day, tells the placing authority and the parents or carers where it is safe to do so, and checks that any referral has been made and acknowledged. Any lesson for the school is recorded.

Trips, visits and events. The trip leader carries these numbers, Notice of Concern forms and each pupil's emergency contacts, and the numbers are part of the risk assessment for the trip. A concern that arises on a trip follows the same steps.

Concerns about the Head Teacher or the Proprietor. If the concern is about the Head Teacher, contact the Chair of the School Governance Board, Mark O'Donnell. If it is about the Proprietor, phone the LADO team (see Appendix 3).

APPENDIX 9: BIRMINGHAM'S THRESHOLD FRAMEWORK FOR TRIAGE CATEGORIES

The DSL uses this framework with Birmingham's Right Help, Right Time guidance (see section 7.4) to decide whether a child's needs are universal, need early help or need statutory social care. It is reproduced as published by Birmingham City Council, Birmingham Children's Trust, West Midlands Police and the NHS. It is a guide, and professional judgement always applies.

	1. Universal: children with no additional needs Has needs met within universal provision. May need limited intervention to avoid needs arising.	2. Early Help: children with additional needs Has additional needs identified that can be met within identified resources through a single agency response and robust partnership working.	3. Statutory Social Care: children with complex multiple needs Statutory service to address complex, multiple needs or is in need of protection.
Child developmental needs	• Good education attendance above 90% • Meeting developmental & learning milestones • Has emotional well-being • Ability to protect self and be protected • Resilient and able to adapt to change • Physically healthy • Age-appropriate self care & independence skills • Positive sense of self and abilities • Ability to express needs	• Concerns about impact of absence/truancy, exclusion from school • Concerns about isolated children not accessing services • Persistent poor behaviour in school and risk of persistent social exclusions • Mental health issues affecting development needs, including concerns about self harm • Children frequently missing from home • Disability or additional special educational needs • Potential for becoming or is not in education, employment or training • Concerns about difficulty in achieving in education • Concerns about meeting developmental milestones • Missing health appointments/delayed response in ensuring child's health needs met • Early signs of offending/anti-social behaviour • Concerns about being drawn into anti-social or criminal behaviour, including gang involvement and association with organised crime groups • Concerns about under-age sexual activity/inappropriate age related sexualised behaviours • Concerns about early signs of drug/alcohol misuse • Low level emotional & behavioural issues that may be linked to attachment and/or emotional development delay • Concerns about children who were previously in care, children who do not live with their birth parents i.e. adopted children, Special Guardianship Orders, Kinship Care	• Serious concerns about impact of significant and complex learning/physical disability on child's welfare • Regular missed health appointments with evidence of acute negative impact on child's development • Chronic drug/alcohol misuse impacting negatively on child's welfare/development • Peer on peer abuse with significant negative impact • Significant harmful sexual behaviour including persistent evidence of inappropriate sexual knowledge and behaviour for age • Significant evidence of exploitation (e.g. sexual, criminal, gang affiliation and drug exploitation) • Severe and complex mental health issues affecting development needs, including significant self harm • Acute risk of failure to thrive • Teenage parent/pregnancy under the age of 13/or having sex (statutory rape) • Child victims of modern slavery, human trafficking, involved in terrorist activity • Chronic risk of harm from consistently missing from home • Unaccompanied minors • Unexplained non-accidental, suspicious injury • Non-mobile child with unexplained bruising • Evidence of physical, emotional or sexual abuse or neglect
Family and environment	• Stable relationships with caregivers • Housed, good diet and kept healthy • Supportive networks • Access to positive activities • Positive relationships with	• Dental decay due to poor hygiene • Chronic/recurring health problems • Concerns about emotional/mental health issues • Concerns about impact on upon children who are young carers • Poor or unstable parent/child relationships	• Person posing a risk to a child • No recourse to public funds • Unborn child placed at risk, previous children or siblings removed • Severe and chronic dental decay • Imminent risk of family homelessness • 16/17 year old presenting as

	peers • Attending health appointments, including those for pregnant mothers	• Concerns about being bullied or bullying behaviour • Poor housing & home environment impacting on child • Concerns about impact of community harassment/discrimination • Risk of relationship breakdown/inter-parental conflict • Concerns about domestic abuse and coercive control • Family bereavement • Concerns about pregnant mother with safeguarding risk factors • Concerns regarding internet safety • Concerns about teenage pregnancy • Housing tenancy at risk • Concerns about transient and avoidant families • Concerns of potential vulnerabilities to radicalisation	homeless • Domestic abuse resulting in child being at risk of significant harm • Forced marriage, honour based violence, female genital mutilation • Allegation of harm by a person in a position of trust • Private fostering
Parents and carers	• Protected by carers • Secure and caring home • Receive and act on information, advice and guidance • Age appropriate boundaries maintained	• Inconsistent care arrangements • Poor relationships impacting upon child's development • Low income/poverty impacting upon child's welfare • Poor supervision by parent/carer • Concerns about parent's own health needs impacting on child • Poor response to child's physical, emotional or health needs • Historic context of parents/carers own childhood, i.e. adverse childhood experiences • Controlled or stable substance abuse	• Parental learning or physical disability impacting upon child's welfare and safety • Significant concerns about substance misuse or mental health impacting on parenting • Fabricated or induced illness. (Parent or carer exaggerations or deliberately causes symptoms of illness in a child) • Parental disguised compliance • Persistent failure to meet a child's basic, physical and/or psychological needs • Imminent risk of significant harm due to poor supervision • Developmental milestones not being consistently met due to persistent failure of parenting • Persistent evidence of negative impact of parental/carers relationship breakdown on the child